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Product Management Casebook

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An in-depth summary of Industry Best Practices , Structures, Analysis, Cases & Critiques

2023-24

Acknowledgement

Here, we have tried to create a comprehensive preparation material tailored to addressing the needs of the students who wish to follow the path of product management. This would not have been possible without the invaluable contributions of various stakeholders who joined us at different stages of this journey.

First and foremost, we express our heartfelt appreciation to our team of collaborators who diligently engaged in the demanding process of conceiving, assembling, and refining the content. We would also like to extend our thanks to the numerous individuals within the club, as well as current students and alumni, for generously providing their valuable insights and feedback on the material. Furthermore, we owe our gratitude to the creative and editorial team for their instrumental role in shaping the content into its current form.

We genuinely thank our team of collaborators :

Atreyee Chakraborty, Rohit Kumaravelan, Chirayu Prasad, Vignesh Hariharan, Nitisha Mohanty, Sabuj K Raj, Nandita Biswas, Rushikesh Zoting, Arka Dasgupta, Dhananjayan, Abhishek Bapna, Tushar Sable, Dominic Maxwell J, Arshia Mitra, Dharma R, Mrinal Agarwal, Saloni Pai Raiker, Paranthaman K, Saransh Maheshwari, Shivangi Pandey, Prathyusha Gollamudi, Amartya Saha, C Akhil

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Frameworks & Methodologies

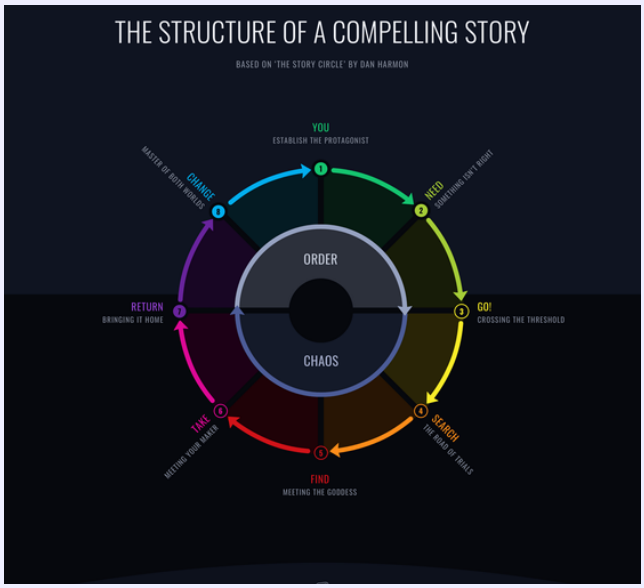


Frameworks & Methodologies

1.1 Design Framework

CIRCLES

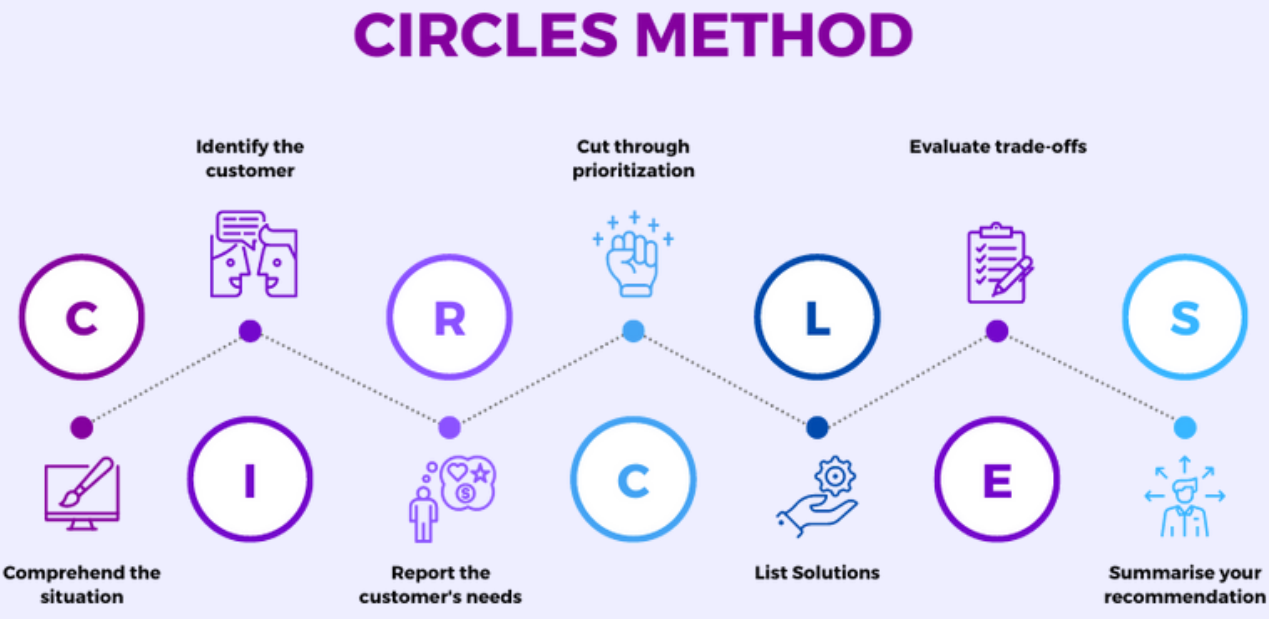
If you're gearing up for a product management interview, there's a good chance you'll face design-related questions that test your problem-solving skills. So, how do you structure your thoughts under pressure? Enter the CIRCLES Method, a systematic approach to tackle design problems, making your answers both comprehensive and impressive.



What is the CIRCLES Method?
Introduced by Google Ventures' Jake Knapp, the CIRCLES Method stands for:

Comprehend the situation
Identify the customer
Report customer's needs
Cut, through prioritisation
List solutions
Evaluate tradeoffs
Summarise your recommendation

These seven steps help product managers and interviewees alike keep track of essential facets of problem-solving



Frameworks & Methodologies

Core Concepts
At the core of the CIRCLES Method are three key concepts:

The Situation: Understand the problem before you try to solve it.
The Customer: Identify the user to design for them effectively.
Prioritization: Not all problems need immediate attention; prioritize wisely.

The 7 Steps Simplified
Comprehend the situation: Ask the "5 W's and H" (Who, What, Why, How, When, Where) to gather all possible information. It sets the stage for focused problem-solving.

Identify the customer: Know your user. Generate personas to empathize with their needs and frustrations. This sets you on a path to a user-centric solution.

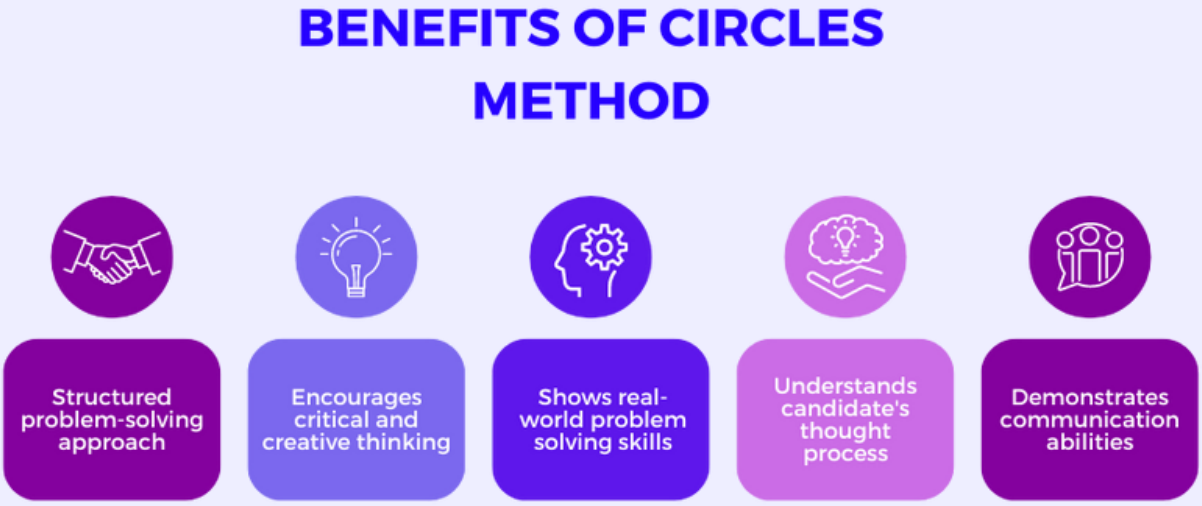
Report customer's needs: Transform your understanding of customer needs into clear requirements or use-cases. In interviews, this manifests as your capacity to articulate what the customer wants effectively.

Cut, through prioritization: Use prioritization models (discussed later) to focus on problems that yield the most significant impact. In interviews, demonstrate your prioritization skills by citing past decision-making examples.

List Solutions: Unleash your creativity. Brainstorm potential solutions, narrowing down to the most effective ones. This shows your problem-solving and creative capabilities.

Evaluate Tradeoffs: Assess the pros, cons, and implications of each solution. Demonstrating this in an interview reveals your foresight and critical thinking skills.

Summarize your recommendation: Put it all together in a coherent and concise presentation. This demonstrates your communication skills and wraps up your solution neatly.



1.2 Product Prioritization Frameworks

In today's fast-paced technology world, Product Managers (PMs) are the navigators steering the ship through choppy waters, rife with shifting priorities and limited resources. PMs must make strategic decisions to ensure the product's success, and align their focus with the business and customer needs. This is where product prioritization frameworks come in.

1. **Value vs. Complexity Quadrant:** Helps to assess a feature's impact against its implementation complexity.
2. **Kano Model:** Focuses on customer satisfaction and product features.
3. **Weighted Scoring:** Prioritizes based on multiple weighted criteria.
4. **RICE Framework:** Examines Reach, Impact, Confidence, and Effort.
5. **ICE Scoring Model:** Focuses on Impact, Confidence, and Ease.
6. **MoSCoW Method:** Categorizes into Must-haves, Should-haves, Could-haves, and Won't-haves.
7. **Opportunity Scoring:** Measures the importance of a feature against customer satisfaction.



(a) Value vs. Complexity Quadrant:

The Value vs. Complexity Model is an essential tool in a product manager's toolkit for effective prioritisation. The challenge lies in balancing limited resources while aiming to deliver high value, especially when customer data or market research is scant.

In this model, two dimensions are considered: **'Business Value'** and **'Implementation Complexity'**. Initiatives are evaluated and plotted on a quadrant that is segmented into four areas: high value-low complexity, high value-high complexity, low value-low complexity, and low value-high complexity. The objective is simple but powerful: Identify initiatives that offer the maximum value for the minimum effort.

- **High value, low complexity:** The "low-hanging fruits." These initiatives should be your top priority as they offer immediate business value with the least effort involved. These are your quick wins.
- **High value, high complexity:** Worth prioritizing but require substantial resources. The decision to go ahead often depends on ROI considerations and long-term strategic alignment.
- **Low value, low complexity:** These are the 'nice-to-haves.' They can be executed during downtime or when resources become momentarily available, but they aren't urgent.
- **Low value, high complexity:** The danger zone. These initiatives should usually be avoided as they consume substantial resources while offering minimal returns.

Each initiative's value score should consider

both customer benefits and direct business impacts. The complexity score may include operational costs, developer hours, and potential risks among other factors. By assigning numerical values to each, you ensure a consistent, objective prioritization process.

The real strength of the Value vs. Complexity Model lies in its flexibility and applicability across various scenarios:

New Product Development: Focus high-impact features that can give you a competitive edge right out of the gate.
Resource Constraints: Identify what can be realistically accomplished, ensuring the team focuses only on what brings the most value.
Objective Assessment: Sanity check, cutting through team biases or unwarranted enthusiasm around particular initiatives.

Summary
The Value vs. Complexity Model is a strategic exercise that brings alignment among stakeholders and clarity to the roadmap. For product managers striving to make data-driven, high-impact decisions, mastering this model can be a game-changer.

(b) KANO Model:

Traditional models like cost-benefit analysis offer some guidance, but they often fall short in factoring in customer delight and satisfaction. This is where the KANO Model shines. Named after Dr. Noriaki Kano, this model provides a framework that places customer satisfaction at the forefront, enabling product teams to make strategic decisions on what features to develop, enhance, or eliminate.

Understanding the KANO Model
Unlike conventional prioritization frameworks, the KANO Model categorizes features based on customer reactions, divided into five main types: Basic (Threshold), Performance, Excitement, Indifferent, and Dissatisfaction. This approach emphasizes the dual criteria of customer satisfaction and implementation investment, making it a compelling model to use in various product life cycles.

Basic (Threshold) Features:
These are the non-negotiables—features so fundamental that their absence would lead to customer dissatisfaction. For instance, a turn signal in a car is a basic feature.

Performance Features:
These are the features that customers are aware they want and will likely compare against competitors. The investment in performance features correlates directly with an increase in customer satisfaction.

Excitement Features:
These are the "Wow" factors, features that customers didn't know they wanted but end up delighting them immensely.

Features that induce **indifference** or **dissatisfaction** are best avoided, as they either don't affect customer choices or lead to negative experiences.

How It Works
The process starts with an internal discussion within the product team to identify and categorize potential new features. After this, direct customer feedback is sought through surveys, interviews, and other channels to validate or adjust these categories.

Criticisms and Adaptations

While the KANO Model is highly insightful, it's not without criticisms. The customer's needs and perceptions are not static; they change over time. What is considered an excitement feature today may become a basic feature tomorrow. Therefore, constant re-evaluation is necessary for the model to remain effective.

Summary

The KANO Model offers a comprehensive yet straightforward way for product managers to prioritize features based on the degree of customer satisfaction they bring. Its adaptability and focus on customer input make it a robust framework for any product manager aiming to build a product that not only satisfies but delights the end-user.

(c) RICE Framework:

RICE stands for Reach, Impact, Confidence, and Effort. This model helps in prioritising various product features or initiatives by assigning them a score based on these four criteria. Let's delve into each component.

The Four Pillars of RICE

1. Reach: This is a numerical estimate of the number of people your initiative is expected to affect over a specific timeframe. Whether you measure reach in terms of customer transactions, free-trial signups, or user engagement, your reach score becomes the benchmark for the project's potential scope.

2. Impact: This quantifies the extent to which the initiative will affect the users it reaches. Impact can be hard to measure, but it's crucial. Intercom recommends a tiered system, ranging from 'massive impact' (3) to 'minimal impact' (0.25), to assist in gauging this nebulous element.

3. Confidence: This represents how certain you are about your estimates for Reach and Impact. If your reach score is based on solid data but the impact is more of a gut feeling, the confidence score balances this out. Scores can range from high (100%) to low (50%). Anything below 50% is considered a 'moonshot,' requiring reevaluation.

4. Effort: The sole denominator in the RICE equation, Effort estimates the total resources required to bring the project to fruition, usually in 'person-months.' This score is pivotal for evaluating the cost associated with each benefit you expect to gain.

Why Use RICE Model?

RICE compiles various factors into a single numerical value, enabling product managers to make decisions based on data rather than intuition. Thus data-driven decisions with **minimized bias** can be achieved. The score provides a quantifiable rationale for why certain projects are prioritized, making it easier to defend these choices to stakeholders like executive staff.

How to Calculate the RICE Score

The RICE score is calculated as follows:

RICE Score = (Reach×Impact×Confidence)/Effort

Practical Tips:

Be Consistent: Make sure you're consistent in your timeframes and units across all four categories to ensure an apples-to-apples comparison.

Revisit Scores: The markets and resources change, so should your RICE scores. Make it a habit to revisit and update them regularly.

Summary

The RICE Scoring Model is an indispensable tool for any product manager looking to make informed, unbiased, and defensible decisions. It takes the guesswork out of product management, transforming it into a more scientific and successful endeavour.

(d) MoSCoW Method:

Developed by software expert Dai Clegg at Oracle, MoSCoW is often used in Agile project management frameworks. The method breaks down requirements into "Must have, Should have, Could have, Will not have".

Must-have (M): These are non-negotiable requirements that are essential for project success. If any of these elements are missing, the project is considered incomplete.

Should-have (S): Important but not critical for immediate project success. These elements enhance the project but are not vital.

Could-have (C): These are nice-to-have elements that can be sacrificed without affecting the project's core functionality.

Will-not-have (W): These elements are recognized but are not a priority for the current project phase.

Why Use MoSCoW?

MoSCoW establishes clarity among project stakeholders, making it easier to move forward. By prioritizing must-haves, the method ensures **focus on Minimum Viable Product (MVP)** as well as proper resource allocation.

However, there can be **Uncertainty** (items in the 'Will-not-have' category, particularly regarding whether they will ever be implemented) and **Subjectivity**.

Summary

The MoSCoW method is a simple yet effective tool for prioritising project requirements. Its straightforward categorization helps teams focus on essential elements, making it a vital asset in Agile project management. While the method is not without its limitations, its benefits make it a robust choice for project teams.

(e) ICE Scoring Model:

The ICE Scoring Model, pioneered by Sean Ellis—the mind behind "growth hacking"—provides a quick and straightforward way to rank potential projects or features. Here's how it works and why it might be the right fit for your team.

The Three Components of ICE

1. Impact: Measured on a scale of 1 to 10, impact assesses how significantly the project will influence a targeted key metric.

2. Confidence: Also scored between 1 and 10, confidence gauges your certainty that the project will achieve the predicted impact.

3. Ease: This measures the level of effort required to complete the project, again on a 1-10 scale.

How to Calculate the ICE Score
The ICE score is calculated as follows:
ICE Score = (Impact×Confidence×Ease)

Why Use ICE?
Being one of the simplest methods, it leads to fast decision-making. It also helps relative prioritization amongst different projects with its "good-enough" approximation of scores, acting as a proxy for projects' importance.

However, there remain risks of subjectivity and **Bias toward low-hanging fruit** (low Ease score can significantly drag down a project's ICE score. Thus for organizations with multiple, concurrent objectives, ICE may fall short. Hence, as best practice, collaborate with different teams and maintain a consistent definition for the scales.

Summary
ICE Scoring is a rapid, straightforward prioritization tool which can be both a strength and a limitation—so it's crucial to use it in contexts where speed and relative ranking take precedence over detailed analysis.

(f) Weighted Scoring Model:

Also known as a weighted scorecard, this model is a project management technique used to prioritize actions, features, or investments. One popular variation of this model is the Six Sigma prioritization matrix.

Understanding the Model:
Here's a simplified guide to employing the Weighted Scoring Model in your next project:

Step I: List Your Options
Begin by listing down all the potential elements or actions you're considering for the project. This could include product features, software choices, hiring options, or any other variables. The list should be exhaustive but not ranked in any particular order yet.

Step 2: Determine the Criteria
Identify the criteria that will serve as the basis for weighing each option. This could be cost, risk, time, quality, return on investment (ROI), or any other metrics pertinent to your specific project.

Step 3: Assign Weights
Assign a weight to each in percentage terms that sums up to 100%. For example, if ROI is crucial for your project, you might weigh it at 30%, while factors like cost and effort could be assigned 20% each.

Step 4: Create the Matrix
Construct a chart where you multiply the weight of each criterion by the score you've assigned to each option for that criterion. Sum these up to get a weighted score for each option. The option with the highest weighted score should, theoretically, be the most favourable choice.

Why Use a Weighted Scoring Model?
Objective decision-making, collaborative evaluation among stakeholders and team members, and resource optimization (allocation) can be achieved.

Summary
As projects grow increasingly complex, the need for such organized decision-making frameworks only becomes more crucial. So, when you're in a decision-making quandary, give the Weighted Scoring Model a try.

(g) Opportunity Scoring Model:

Opportunity Scoring Model, a versatile tool originally derived from Tony Ulwick's outcome-driven-innovation (ODI) approach.

What is Opportunity Scoring?

Opportunity Scoring is a prioritisation method used to identify high-impact, yet underperforming features in a product. The approach involves asking customers to rate the importance and satisfaction levels of various product features. Those features that score high in importance but low in satisfaction are marked as opportunities.

How to Calculate the Opportunity Score

The Opportunity score is calculated as follows:

Opportunity Score =
Importance + max(importance - satisfaction, 0)

Features with the highest 'importance' scores and the lowest 'satisfaction' scores are prioritised for development.

Why Use Opportunity Scoring Model?

Broad Applications

Although it originated in product management, Opportunity Scoring is also useful in other business areas like marketing, sales, and IT. Generally called gap analysis in these sectors, the approach helps teams weigh the relative ROI of closing identified gaps with available resources.

The Advantage over Traditional Models

The critical differentiator in Opportunity Scoring is the emphasis on what customers are trying to achieve, rather than how they think the product should do it. Unlike traditional gap analysis that equally considers importance and satisfaction, Opportunity Scoring gives double weight to importance, thereby zeroing in on outcomes that customers value the most.

Resource Optimization

Besides identifying the most promising areas for innovation, Opportunity Scoring can also highlight areas where resources are being wasted.

Summary

The Opportunity Scoring Model provides a robust mechanism to identify and focus on key areas for product improvement. By honing in on what customers find important but currently dissatisfying, this model offers a targeted approach to optimising resources and maximising ROI. With its roots in outcome-driven innovation and broad applicability across various business sectors, Opportunity Scoring is more than a product management tool; it's a comprehensive strategy for sustainable business growth.

1.3 Metrics

A very important part of both interviews and case submissions are the metrics one chooses, and hence the following frameworks will help you to chart the accurate metrics. Each framework is used to serve a particular purpose - customer acquisition & revenue growth, user experience, etc.



(a) AARRR

The AARRR framework, popularly known as the "Pirate Metrics," offers startup founders and product managers a proven model to drive business growth.

What is AARRR?
AARRR is an acronym that outlines the customer's journey in the digital landscape.

Acquisition: This refers to where your users come from, whether through search engines, social media, or other channels. Eg: SEO Performance like number of people clicked on your Facebook/Google ad to visit website

Activation: This means ensuring users have a "positive" initial experience with your product. Eg: The number of users who signed up (could be free sign-ups too)

Retention: This tracks how often users come back. Eg: Time spent on the platform, number of times app opened, website revisits

Referral: This measures how likely customers are to refer your product to others. Eg: Number of referrals per user

Revenue: This aims to understand how you can monetize user behavior. Eg: Number of products purchase, type of user's subscription plan

The idea is to narrow down focus to actionable metrics that help identify areas for growth and scaling.

Tools for Each Stage
Acquisition: Google Analytics, KISSmetrics
Activation: Hotjar, FullStory
Retention: Amplitude, ZenDesk
Referral: Referral Factory, Refersion
Revenue: Dreamdata, Revenueanalytics.com

Summary
AARRR is not just a catchy acronym; it's a robust framework that provides a structured approach to understanding and influencing customer behaviour. It helps product managers identify vital KPIs, thereby enabling them to make data-driven decisions for sustainable growth.
AARRR allows startups and product managers to focus on metrics that genuinely matter, streamlining their strategies for acquisition, activation, retention, referral, and revenue. This targeted approach can significantly increase the likelihood of building a successful, sustainable business.

(b) HEART

In today's digital landscape, the quality of the user experience (UX) can be the linchpin of a product's success or failure. Google, a leader in the tech industry, identified this gap and came up with an innovative, holistic framework known as the HEART Framework.

What is the Google HEART Framework?
Developed by Google's UX Research experts, the HEART Framework is a set of user-centered metrics aimed at providing a comprehensive assessment of the quality of UX. The framework breaks down the evaluation into five key factors:

Happiness: Measures users' satisfaction levels through app ratings, user satisfaction surveys, and the Net Promoter Score (NPS).

Engagement: Evaluates the frequency of user interactions, including session lengths and specific actions like the number of photos uploaded.

Adoption: Focuses on the number of new users and the percentage of customers using a new feature.

Retention: Assesses the percentage of users who keep returning to the product.

Task Success: Measures how efficiently and effectively users can achieve their goals within the product.

These dimensions allow you to assess not only the product's performance but also the emotional resonance and satisfaction it delivers to your users.

The HEART Process

Step I: Set Goals
Goal-setting is pivotal to ensure that every team member is aligned. "What do we want a customer to tweet after using our product?" You should narrow your goals down to no more than three.

Step 2: Define Signals
define signals, which are user actions or behaviours that can indicate whether a goal is being met or not. For instance, if the goal is to enhance the search experience, a signal could be the number of users who enter search queries but do not click on any results, which could imply irrelevant results.

Step 3: Choose Metrics
Metrics make your signals quantifiable. For example, if your goal is user happiness, a suitable metric could be the Net Promoter Score. Google UX Researcher Kerry Rodden emphasises the importance of normalisation: as your user base grows, it's essential to normalise results through ratios, percentages, or averages per user, instead of relying solely on raw figures.

Summary
Measuring UX isn't just about ticking off a checklist of standard metrics. For a nuanced understanding of your users' experience, a comprehensive framework like Google's HEART is indispensable. By setting targeted goals, defining relevant signals, and choosing appropriate metrics, you can obtain a more in-depth understanding of how users interact with your product, what keeps them coming back.

Comment: All the metric frameworks can be used for measuring the performance of the solutions suggested during design cases.

(c) North Star

What is a north star metric?

It is the key measure of success for the product team in a company. It defines the relationship between the customer problems that the product team is trying to solve and the revenue that the business aims to generate by doing so.

- It gives clarity and alignment on what the product team needs to be optimizing for and what can be traded off.
- Most importantly, it holds product accountable to an outcome.

A team identifies a single, meaningful metric and a handful of contributing inputs. Product teams work to influence those inputs, which in turn drive the metric. The North Star is a leading indicator of sustainable growth.

How do you select a good product North Star?

When choosing a north star metric, Make sure to ensure that your metric meets the following criteria:

- **It expresses value:** Your north star metric should capture what the customer uses the product for and the value it brings.
- **It indicates success:** It should go beyond just the purchase of your product and provide details about how it's impacting your customers.
- **It is measurable:** Clearly defined north star. For example, tracking opinions or immeasurable data will not deliver reliable results.
- **It is clear and actionable:** It should be a simple and easily understandable metric which is within your control and something which can be improved.

Examples of good north star metrics:

Let's dive deep and understand the details with some North Star Metric examples:

Product/ Feature	Ideal Goal	North Star Metric
Amazon, Flipkart, Walmart	Users ordering more from their websites	#Orders, #Total Orders per week
Netflix, Spotify, Primevideo, facebook	Increase in User content consumption/ session time	Time Spent per user, DAU, MAU, # new subscribers
Tinder, Bumble	Users need to find more succesful matches/Partners	#No. of matches /week
Uber, Ola	Users availing ride services more	#No. of ride bookings or #Kms/Miles per week*
Naukri.com	Users getting desired Jobs	#Shortlists created via the portal

Can a product have more than one product north star?

No! NSM is the single metric that defines the overall success of the product. But, it is important to have a set of metrics that complement the NSM. NSM can change with the maturity of the company or the product.

Example: When Instagram was relatively new, the primary goal at that time was getting more and more users to the platform. At that time, an acquisition based NSM would have made more sense. But today, An NSM like the "Total minutes spent per week" works well today since insta is very popular now and has a very large user base already.

*Here, distance is better metric as longer rides are valuable

1.4 The Five Whys?

In today's rapidly evolving tech landscape, Product Managers (PMs) are akin to the captains of a ship navigating through stormy waters. Faced with fluctuating user engagement metrics, shifting team dynamics, and escalating customer demands, PMs need tools that help them make sense of the complexities. One such critical tool that can help product managers is the 5 Whys framework. This analytical method, rooted in Six Sigma and Lean methodologies, allows PMs to dig deep into issues to uncover underlying problems.

What is the 5 Whys Analysis?

5 Whys is an interrogative technique aimed at exploring the cause-and-effect relationships underlying specific problems. By repeatedly asking "Why?" to every answer you get, you move closer to identifying the root cause of an issue. Although the number '5' is more of a guideline than a strict rule, it generally points to the depth needed to get to the bottom of things.

How the 5 Whys Works in Product Management

When PMs encounter challenges like declining Monthly Active User (MAU) growth, the 5 Whys framework offers a structured approach to problem-solving. Let's examine a hypothetical scenario to illuminate its practical application.

Example: Declining MAU Growth

I. Why is MAU growth declining?
Answer: Users quit the app after a few months.

2. Why do they quit?
Answer: The app does not continue to meet users' evolving needs.

3. Why doesn't it meet their needs?
Answer: The development team has not been able to roll out planned new features.

4. Why haven't new features been rolled out?
Answer: The development team is swamped with solving customer issues, exceeding the planned hours for this work.

5. Why are they spending so much time on customer issues?
Answer: A particular feature, X, was released prematurely and has numerous bugs.

This analysis reveals the core issue to be a bug-ridden feature, shifting the PM's focus from merely trying to boost MAU to addressing this root cause. Resolving the feature's bugs will likely have a cascading positive effect on the MAU numbers, making this the priority.

Summary

The 5 Whys framework demystifies complex issues, aligns team efforts, and points the way toward effective solutions. Over-reliance on this technique can also potentially lead to a narrow viewpoint, ignoring the broader context or interconnected issues. It's crucial to use the 5 Whys in conjunction with other tools and metrics for a more holistic view.

Comment: The 5WHY framework can be used to pose the initial clarifying questions to the interviewer during design interviews or RCA interviews.

1.5 REAN Framework

REAN is designed to facilitate planning and analysis in complex marketing environments. It stands for:

Reach: Activities to increase brand awareness, both online and offline.

Engage: Multi-channel initiatives aimed at engaging prospective customers.

Activate: Clearly defined and tracked calls-to-action to motivate potential customers.

Nurture: Strategies to maintain customer relationships through CRM, email newsletters, etc.

How to Map Goals Using REAN

Reach: For instance, you aim for a 50% increase in website visitors via SEO and PPC for specific keywords.

Engage: Aiming for a 50% increase in click depth and duration by incorporating testimonials, case studies, and other content forms.

Activate: Goals could include increasing sales through the shopping cart and more downloads of informational whitepapers. This is achieved by A/B testing various website elements like headlines, buttons, and images.

Nurture: This could involve receiving additional orders and collecting prospect data through forms and newsletters.

Who Benefits from the REAN Framework?

The REAN framework is versatile and benefits a variety of team members:

Senior Management: A structured model like REAN can lend credence to decisions. For example, if senior management suggests adding a splash page, it can be A/B tested for effectiveness. Data-driven insights make it easier to discard ideas that aren't working.

Marketing Team: With REAN, the marketing team can develop targeted strategies for each phase, measuring and optimizing as needed.

Tech Teams: For the technically inclined, REAN provides a structured, logical path for conversion optimization. The clarity offered by the framework helps them align better with marketing objectives.

Why Use REAN in Product Management?

Data-Driven Decisions: REAN encourages the use of analytics and customer data at every step, ensuring that your strategies are continually fine-tuned.

Structured Approach: It offers a step-by-step guide to approaching marketing, covering all the bases from brand awareness to customer retention.

Inter-Departmental Alignment: By offering a common language and set of objectives, REAN facilitates better communication between different departments, ensuring everyone is on the same page.

Summary

The REAN framework provides a detailed, structured model for planning and implementing marketing strategies in product management. By mapping out specific goals for reach, engagement, activation, and nurturing, it serves as an effective guide for various stakeholders.

Product Design Cases



Product Design Case I

Design a Child Safety Tracker

Interviewer: Design a tracker that aids in keeping children safe outside their home environment

Candidate: Let me just clarify the problem statement. I need to design a product that helps in keeping children safe outside their homes. Is there any limitation on whether the product needs to be a software or hardware or is it open-ended?

Interviewer: You may feel free to design any product of your choosing.

Candidate: Okay sure. I would like to start by identifying the users and their personas for this product. They would be the following -

1. Parents: Parents concerned about the well-being of their children. These are mainly working parents with children aged 8-15 who may leave their children with help. Their children attend school, extra-curricular classes and play with friends.
2. Active Children: Children want to have the freedom to go out without their parents constantly checking up on them. They are 8-15 years old children who attend school, extra-curricular classes, and play with friends.
3. Special Needs Children: Parents are especially worried if certain specific needs of their children are catered to properly.

I would like to first define the user needs of these segments and pick the most critical one to solve. Is that okay?

Interviewer: That sounds good. Let's de-prioritise special needs children as they may require special functionality and we want to create a mass market product.

Candidate: Okay, then, I'll define pain points of the two primary user personas

1. Parents
   - Want to make sure their child is not going to dangerous places when they are outside playing with their friends
   - Want to know as soon as possible when there is an emergency/ danger
   - May want to know what places their children go to when travelling alone (say, going to & coming from school)
2. Children
   - Don't want to constantly call their guardian about what they're doing
   - Want to participate in their games & other activities without their parents bothering them

Interviewer: Okay that seems fair but what kind of product do you have in mind to address these needs.

Candidate: I think these needs can be addressed by three different kinds of products. These are -

1. A kid friendly smart-watch: A smart-watch that kids can wear and operate without any connectivity to a smartphone.
2. A kid-friendly smartphone: A smartphone with limited functionality to enable parents and their children to communicate with each other without full feature functionality that parents might think affects negatively on their children
3. A mobile app: A mobile app that kids can download on their smartphones to communicate with their parents, update their location, etc.

Product Design Case I

Interviewer: These seem like good ideas but how will you decide which of these should we choose?

Comment: Candidate can sketch a prioritization matrix on paper.

Candidate: I would like to create a value-effort matrix* to assess the prioritization of these products -

A smartwatch will provide the highest value since it will address all the concerns of parents and will not prove to be a bother for children to carry. So, high impact and medium effort.

A mobile app requires a child to carry a smartphone and thus it will not address the need of parents to not give their child a smartphone. So, medium impact and low effort.

A smartphone will address parents' concerns but will require more development, will be more expensive than a smartwatch, and will prove to be another item for children to carry. So, high impact, high effort.

Solution	Impact	Effort	Prioritisa-tion
Kid-friendly smart watch	High	Med	1
A Mobile App	Med	Low	3
Kid-friendly Smartphone	High	High	2

Next, I would like to detail some features of my prioritized product i.e. a smartwatch

Interviewer: Sure, you can go ahead.

Candidate: I think the following features are necessary to build this product to address user needs

1. An emergency SOS button that automatically calls their parents. It can be used by the children as well as other people in case the child is in an emergency
2. A GPS tracker that updates parents of their child's location. The parents can also set boundaries on their linked apps and get alerts if their child goes outside these boundaries
3. A simplified UI that can be used for short voice messages that go directly to their parents
4. Heartbeat tracker to ensure and track the child's fitness (deprioritized)

Interviewer: These seem fair but how will the parents interact with children on their smartwatch?

Candidate: Yes, for that we would also need to build an app that parents will download on their smartphones through which they can track their child's location, send them messages and get notifications.

Interviewer: Agreed. An app is necessary to provide connected access for the parents. I would next want you to define a brief go-to-market strategy for this product as well.

Candidate: Sure. I believe the best strategy would be to partner with an existing smartwatch or watch brand like fasttrack. We can build the features, UI and app for the product and the partner company and provide their expertise in producing cool-looking watches that are attractive to children. Would you like me to further define this strategy across the value chain?

Interviewer: No this is all I was looking for.

*Value for users & Effort by Product Team

Product Design Case I

Comment: Even if not asked explicitly, mention success metrics at the end.

Candidate: Great. Next, I would like to define some success metrics for this product. These would be primarily -

- Acquisition: No. of products sold, No. of linked app downloads
- Engagement: No. of voice messages sent per user, activewear time per day
- Retention: Churn Rate (No. of watches no longer being actively worn)

Interviewer: These sound good. Before we close this case, I would like you to summarise the product by defining its product vision.

Candidate: Sure. The vision I have in mind is -

A lot of parents give smartphones to their children in this age group but are apprehensive about the harmful effects of smartphones. Thus parents want a solution that still fulfils the basic needs of safety tracking, emergency SOS and communication that they can give to their children. Children also want something cool to wear which is not too cumbersome to carry.
A smartwatch is the best solution which will provide parents the peace of mind and which will attract children with its cool design.

Interviewer: Okay great. We can close this case. Thanks!

Candidate: Thank you!

Product Design Case 2

Sustainable Practices in Households

Interviewer: Design a solution that encourages sustainable practices in households to reduce environmental impact.

Comment: The initial step the candidate takes is to clarify any uncertainties or ambiguities present in the problem statement.

Candidate: Would you like the proposed solution to primarily focus on educating and creating awareness among users about sustainable practices, or should it also incorporate practical aspects, such as providing tools, resources, or assistance for the implementation of these practices in their households?

Interviewer: The goal is to create a solution that not only educates and raises awareness about eco-friendly practices but also provides practical tools for households to implement and track their sustainability efforts.

Candidate: That's helpful. I would like to structure my solution by understanding the context, identifying key areas, proposing actionable strategies, and considering potential challenges. Does that sound acceptable?

Interviewer: Sounds good, please proceed.

Comment: Upon grasping the problem statement, the candidate addresses any assumptions and provides an overarching strategy for approaching the problem. This approach ensures that the interviewer is informed of the candidate's broad perspective and remains aligned with the candidate's thought process.

Candidate: Before diving into the design solution, I want to clarify the user segments we're targeting for encouraging sustainable practices in households.

- Eco-conscious individuals: Those who are already environmentally aware and actively looking for ways to enhance their sustainable practices.
- Families and households: They are interested in adopting eco-friendly habits but might need some guidance and practical tools to make the shift.
- Educational Institutions: There's an opportunity to collaborate with educational institutions, such as schools and universities, to incorporate sustainable living education into their curricula.

Before we delve deeper into user needs, Do you have a preferred persona you'd like to focus on, or are you open to exploring all three to determine the best fit for our solution?

Interviewer: You may decide that.

Candidate: I would choose eco-conscious individuals as our primary user persona because:

1. Living a sustainable lifestyle can be a personal commitment, and eco-conscious individuals are already actively seeking ways to enhance their sustainable practices.
2. By focusing on this group, we tap into a motivated audience that can serve as early adopters and influencers, creating a ripple effect within their communities. Additionally, addressing the needs of eco-conscious individuals aligns with my own experiences, making it a strategic choice for our initial user segment.

Product Design Case 2

Comment: The candidate chose a particular user to focus on, but he/she also gave a proper rationale for that. He/she backed it up with a personal experience. This gives more credibility to their assumptions and prioritization criteria. It would have been better if the candidate had gone deeper about the experience.

Candidate: Can I go ahead with this user segment?

Interviewer: Yes, please go ahead.

Candidate: Do you mind if I take a minute to collect my thoughts and make some notes?

Interviewer: Yeah, Sure please take your time.

Candidate: Now, as we delve into understanding user needs, I think it's beneficial to categorize them into three key aspects: Education and Awareness, Practical Implementation, and Community Engagement.

Comment: It's always good to break down the whole process into intermediary stages and figure out the customer in these stages, this helps in getting an exhaustive list of user needs and avoids missing any important part.

Interviewer: That sounds like a thoughtful approach to categorizing user needs. I'm curious to hear your insights on how these aspects will interconnect in the overall solution.

Candidate: User needs identified are

I. Education and Awareness:
   - What features can be incorporated to educate users on the environmental impact of their daily activities?
   - How can the platform continuously update users on emerging trends and technologies in sustainability?
- Practical Implementation:
   - What tools and features will help users implement sustainable practices in their homes and track their carbon footprint and monitor improvements over time?
   - How can the platform collaborate with smart home device manufacturers to integrate sustainable features?
- Community Engagement:
   - How can the platform foster a sense of community among users, encouraging them to share tips and success stories?
   - In what ways can gamification be integrated to make sustainable living more engaging and rewarding?

Interviewer: Okay that seems fair but what kind of product do you have in mind to address these needs?

Candidate: To comprehensively address the identified needs, I propose creating a mobile application with a range of features designed to promote sustainable practices and reduce environmental impact. Here are the key features of the mobile application:

- Regular Updates on Emerging Trends:
   - Users will receive regular updates on the latest trends in sustainable living, utilizing GenAI to personalize these updates based on user preferences and behavior.
- Video Content Explaining Environmental Impact
- User-friendly carbon footprint calculator to help individuals and households assess their environmental impact.
- Gamified challenges will motivate users to adopt and sustain eco-friendly habits, turning sustainable practices into an enjoyable and rewarding experience.

Product Design Case 2

- Platform for sharing tips, success stories, and challenges, fostering a sense of community & integration with Local Businesses:
- Waste-to-Worth Marketplace:
  - Implement a feature where users can sell their recyclable wastes directly to NGO recyclers through the app

Interviewer: Fair enough. But how will you prioritize among these different features?

Candidate: I will prioritize the features based on the value impact on the user's goal and the complexity of development. After the evaluation, I will select Regular Updates on Emerging Trends, the Carbon footprint calculator, Gamified challenges and Waste-to-Worth Marketplace: for the MVP. Would you like me to go into detail about these?

Interviewer: No, this is good. Thanks for your time and all the best.

Candidate: Thank you for your time.

Comment: The candidate could have explained here a bit more about how selected the features for the MVP, however, since the interviewer confirmed then it's fine. It's always better to back up your arguments with data and logic, interviewers are looking for critical thinking about the ability of the candidate.

Product Design Case 3

Design a Cooking Assistant to be embedded in Alexa/Echo

Interviewer: Good afternoon. (Exchange pleasantries). I would like you to imagine yourself as a Product Manager at Amazon and you have to design a Cooking Assistant to be embedded in Alexa/Echo.

Candidate: Okay. Before we begin discussing the Cooking Assistant for Alexa/Echo, I'd like to clarify a few things. Is that alright?

Interviewer: Sure. Please feel free to ask any questions you have.

Candidate: Thank you. To start, could you provide more details on the scope and specific functionality of this Cooking Assistant embedded in Alexa/Echo? What exactly does it do?

Interviewer: The Cooking Assistant in Alexa/Echo is designed to provide voice instructions to users while they cook. It doesn't have video capabilities, so it's entirely audio-based.

Candidate: Thank you for clarifying that. Now, regarding the problem statement, could you specify if there is any specific goal or objective that Amazon wants to achieve?

Interviewer: Certainly. For this scenario, our primary aim is customer acquisition. We want to introduce this new feature to customers, attracting them to use Alexa/Echo as a cooking assistant. Our primary focus is on bringing new users into the ecosystem. You can consider that as Amazon's goal.

Candidate: Understood. To reiterate, this assistant will provide voice instructions to users during cooking, but it won't have video capabilities. We'll primarily focus on customer acquisition as our main goal.

Interviewer: Correct

Candidate: Okay, I think I have a better understanding now. First, I'd like to identify our potential customers. Based on the information provided, I can think of three potential customer segments: Chefs, Amateurs, and Homemakers/people who enjoy cooking. Any particular customer segment you want me to focus on?

Interviewer: No go ahead with your choice and state your reasoning.

Candidate: I'll select Homemakers and people who enjoy cooking as our target segment because they represent a substantial user base with a genuine need for our Cooking Assistant. They cook frequently, seek out new recipes, and are comfortable with audio instructions. Their needs align well with the voice-based Cooking Assistant.

Interviewer: Sounds fair. You can go ahead.

Candidate: Homemakers and people who enjoy cooking primarily need a Cooking Assistant that:

1. Helps them explore new recipes that fit their ingredients.
2. Allows them to listen to specific recipe steps rather than the entire recipe.
3. Provides customized instructions based on serving size.
4. Permits them to enjoy music or listen to the radio while cooking.

Product Design Case 3

Interviewer: Excellent.

Candidate: After considering Reach, Impact, and Effort, here's the prioritization:

1. Listening to recipes
2. Exploring new recipes
3. Customized recipes
4. Listening to music

Based on this analysis, I will prioritise the need for listening to recipes as the focus area.

Interviewer: Good choice. Now, let's discuss potential solutions for addressing this need. What's your proposal?

Candidate: My solution is a step-by-step cooking instructor within Alexa/Echo. It provides detailed recipe explanations at the user's pace. Key features include:

1. Voice-controlled navigation: Users can skip to the next or repeat the last steps using voice commands.
2. Clarification questions: Users can ask questions about quantity and cooking time.
3. Timer functionality: Users can set timers with voice commands.
4. Pause and resume: Users can start and stop recipe instructions as needed.
5. Jump to specific steps: Users can navigate to a step by calling out its title, like "Jump to marinating."

This solution offers flexibility, detailed guidance, and a hands-free cooking experience.

Interviewer: Well-thought-out solution. What are the pros and cons of this approach?

Candidate: Certainly. Pros of the solution include:

1. Flexibility: Users can navigate the recipe as needed.
2. Detailed guidance: Users receive step-by-step instructions.
3. Hands-free experience: Allows for multitasking while cooking.

Cons include:

1. Memory: Users might forget step titles or numbers.
2. Visual cues: Users may struggle with understanding colors or appearance.

However, despite these trade-offs, the pros align with our target audience's needs and preferences.

Interviewer: It seems like you've considered the user's perspective thoroughly. This concludes our interview. All the best!

Candidate: Thank you for the opportunity.

Product Design Case 4

Design a Home System Solution to Control Different Devices

Interviewer: Good afternoon, and thank you for joining us today. I'd like you to assume the role of a Product Manager at a leading smart home technology company. Your task is to design a comprehensive home system solution that allows users to control various devices within their homes.

Candidate: Good afternoon, and thank you for having me. Before we dive into designing the home system solution, I'd like to clarify a few details. Is that okay?

Interviewer: Certainly, clarifications are crucial. Feel free to ask any questions.

Candidate: Before we begin, could you provide more context on the current landscape of smart home technology and the specific challenges or opportunities that I should be aware of?

Interviewer: Smart home technology has seen significant growth in recent years, with an array of devices available, from smart thermostats and lights to security cameras and voice assistants. Challenges include device compatibility, user-friendliness, and ensuring a seamless experience across various platforms.

Candidate: Understood. Now, regarding the problem statement, could you specify any particular goals or objectives for this home system solution?

Interviewer: In this scenario, our primary goal is to create a user-friendly and integrated home system solution that simplifies the control of diverse devices, enhances user convenience, and ensures a high level of security so that more and more users use it.

Candidate: So, our primary objective is to design a comprehensive home system that offers ease of use, device integration, convenience, and security with the end goal of user acquisitions.

Interviewer: Correct.

Candidate: Thank you for the clarifications. I now have a better understanding of the scope and objectives. To begin, I'll identify the types of users who might benefit from this home system solution. I've categorized them into three main segments:

1. Tech-Savvy Homeowners: These users are early adopters of smart home technology. They are comfortable with technology and seek advanced features and customization options.
2. Average Homeowners: This segment includes users who are interested in smart home solutions but prefer simplicity and ease of use. They may not have extensive technical knowledge.
3. Elderly or Disabled Individuals: Some users may have limited mobility or specific accessibility needs. They require an intuitive and accessible solution for controlling devices within their homes.

Should I consider specific user segments or any particular aspects you'd like me to prioritize?

Interviewer: You can proceed with your choice and provide reasoning.

Candidate: Okay. Then, considering the diverse user base we see here, I would like to

Product Design Case 4

propose improvements that focus on Average Homeowners. They represent a significant user base, and their needs often align with broader market trends toward user-friendly and accessible technology. Can we move ahead with that?

Interviewer: Sounds right to me. Please proceed with your analysis.

Candidate: Certainly. The pain points of Average Homeowners could include:

I. Complex Device Control: Users often struggle with managing multiple devices, each with its own app or interface. This complexity can be overwhelming.
2. Lack of Integration: Devices from different manufacturers may not seamlessly communicate with each other. Users may find it challenging to create unified routines or scenarios.
3. Security Concerns: Users worry about the security of their smart home devices, particularly with the potential for hacking or unauthorised access.
4. User Education: Many users are not fully aware of the capabilities and features of their smart devices. They may not be using them to their full potential.

I would like to look at the pain point which we should prioritize and target.

Interviewer: Please go ahead.

Candidate: Since we are focusing on the Average Homeowners segment and aiming for an MVP, I will prioritize the most critical pain point, which is "Complex Device Control." Simplifying device control can have a significant impact on user convenience.

Interviewer: What do you propose to solve this?

Candidate: My solution involves creating a unified mobile app that serves as the central control hub for all smart devices in the home:

I. Device Integration: The app should support a wide range of smart devices, irrespective of the manufacturer. It should use standardized protocols such as Zigbee or Z-Wave to ensure compatibility.
2. Intuitive User Interface: The app's interface should be user-friendly and intuitive, allowing users to easily identify and control their devices. Features like drag-and-drop customization for device arrangements can enhance the user experience.
3. Voice Control: Integration with voice assistants like Amazon Alexa or Google Assistant should be a key feature. This allows users to control devices through voice commands for added convenience.
4. Automation and Scenes: Users should be able to create custom automation routines or scenes that activate multiple devices with a single command. For instance, a "Good Morning" scene could turn on lights and adjust the thermostat.

Interviewer: Your solution seems comprehensive. Would you proceed with implementing all these features in the MVP?

Candidate: No, I will evaluate the solutions based on customer impact and ease of implementation. After the evaluation, I will select the most critical features, such as Device Integration and an Intuitive User Interface, for the MVP. These features address the core pain point and can be developed within a reasonable timeline.

Interviewer: Thank you for presenting these solutions. How would you measure the success of the MVP?

Product Design Case 4

Candidate: Measuring the success of the MVP is crucial to assess its impact and make data-driven decisions for further improvements. I would employ several product management metrics to gauge the MVP's effectiveness:

1. User Engagement Metrics: DAU, MAU & average session duration.
2. User Satisfaction Metrics: NPS and CSAT scores
3. Retention and Churn Metrics: Retention & churn rate
4. Performance Metrics: Latency rate,Avg Load time, crash reports
5. Business Metrics: Revenue Growth

By consistently tracking these product management metrics and setting specific targets, we can evaluate the MVP's performance, make data-driven decisions, and iterate on the product to further enhance user engagement, satisfaction, and overall success.

Interviewer: Great. I think we can conclude here.

Candidate: Thank you.

Product Design Case 5

Design a Fintech Lending Platform

Interviewer: Good afternoon, and thank you for joining us today. I'd like you to assume the Product Manager role at a fintech startup. Your task is to design a money-lending app

Candidate: Let me clarify the problem statement; I have to design a money lending application regarding the problem statement. Could you specify any particular goals or objectives for the lending app?

Interviewer: In this scenario, our primary goal is to create a user-friendly app that would be easy for our direct customers to borrow from us and spend.

Candidate: Is there any specific customer segment you want me to target?

Interviewer: No specific customer segment as such. Can you think of user segments that would benefit most from our lending app?

Candidate: Considering our focus on D2C lending, I'd identify two primary personas: "Young Professionals" seeking quick and accessible loans for personal needs and "Small Business Owners" looking for streamlined financing options without the traditional hurdles. I'd prioritize based on market size and growth potential. Young Professionals could be an initial focus due to the large market and evolving financial needs. Once we establish a strong presence, we can gradually expand to serve the Small Business Owners segment.

Interviewer: Okay. Go ahead.

Candidate: Young professionals often face challenges with limited credit history, high debt-to-income ratios, uncertain income streams, lack of collateral, fear of long-term loans, complexity in understanding loan terms, and a desire to quickly access credit on the go.

Interviewer: How would you address these in the lending app?

Candidate: To address these pain points, we'll implement alternative credit scoring models based on the spending habits and income profile of the customer, offer flexible repayment plans like 3,6,9 months of repayment, simplify language and the user interface, and incorporate educational tools within the app for loan terms.

Interviewer: How would you go about it if we want to have an early market launch?

Candidate: Must-haves include alternative credit scoring and flexible repayment plans as the "Young Professionals" would have a limited credit history accessing credit via u will require alternative credit scoring rather than conventional credit scores. Should-haves encompass a user-friendly interface and short-term loan options to make the loan terms attractive for young professionals who wanna avoid long-term payment commitments. Could-haves involve exploring collateral alternatives and adding educational tools making it easier for them to understand the loan terms that can be developed later. We could also tie up with major e-commerce websites allowing our customers to pay via our app thus increasing our lending portfolio. Won't-haves consist of non-essential features that can be deferred or excluded.

Product Design Case 5

Interviewer: That makes sense. How would you measure the success of our D2C lending app?

Candidate: Key performance indicators (KPIs) such as user acquisition rates, loan approval speed, customer satisfaction scores, and the growth of the loan portfolio would be essential metrics to track.

Interviewer: Thank you for walking through that scenario. Can you summarize the case for me?

Candidate: In this case, we aim to design a user-friendly money lending app for young professionals, focusing on two primary personas: "Young Professionals" seeking quick loans and "Small Business Owners" looking for streamlined financing. Identified pain points include limited credit history, high debt-to-income ratios, uncertain income streams, etc. Solutions involve alternative credit scoring, flexible repayment plans, and a user-friendly interface. Emphasized must-have features like alternative credit scoring and flexible repayment plans.

Product Improvement Case

Improve YouTube for India

Interviewer: Hello. Please have a seat. I would like you to envision yourself as a Product Manager at Google India, and your task is to improve the YouTube platform specifically for the Indian market.

Candidate: Thank you. But before we delve into improving YouTube for India, I'd like to clarify a few details. Is that ok?

Interviewer: Sure, go ahead.

Candidate: To start, could you provide more context on the current state and context of YouTube in India and any specific challenges that I should be aware of?

Interviewer: Certainly. YouTube is a widely used platform in India for sharing and viewing video content across various genres. It has a diverse user base, ranging from urban to rural areas, with varying levels of internet connectivity. There are no specific challenges as such.

Candidate: Thank you for the context. Now, regarding the problem statement, are there any specific objectives or goals I should focus on in this case?

Interviewer: In this scenario, our primary goal is user engagement and growth. We want to improve user satisfaction, increase the time users spend on the platform, and attract new users.

Candidate: Understood. So, our main objective is to enhance user engagement and grow the user base while catering to the Indian market's unique needs and challenges.

Interviewer: Correct.

Candidate: Thank you for the clarifications. I now have a better understanding of the scope and objectives. I will start by identifying the types of users of YouTube in India. I've categorised them into three main segments:

1. Urban Users: These users typically have access to high-speed internet and consume a wide range of content, including entertainment, educational, and lifestyle videos.
2. Rural Users: In rural areas, connectivity can be sporadic. Users in this segment may rely on lower bandwidths and are more likely to access content in regional languages.
3. Content Creators: This group includes individuals and organisations who upload content to YouTube. They play a crucial role in shaping the platform's content landscape.

Should I consider specific user segments or any particular aspects you'd like me to prioritise?

Interviewer: You can go ahead with your choice and state your reasoning.

Candidate: Great. Considering the diversity of users in India, the fact that the majority of India's population resides in rural areas and the fact that Youtube has almost reached saturation in the urban market, I would like to propose improvements that focus on Rural Users.

Product Improvement Case

Interviewer: An excellent choice. Please proceed with your analysis.

Candidate: Certainly. The pain points of rural users could be:

I. Language and Content Preferences: Rural users often prefer content in their regional languages or dialects. Finding content that caters to their language preferences can be difficult, as the majority of content on YouTube is in English or Hindi
2. Educational Needs: For many rural users, YouTube serves as a valuable educational resource. Access to quality educational content, particularly in local languages, is crucial for their personal and professional development.
3. Limited Internet Connectivity: Rural areas frequently have limited access to high-speed internet. Users may struggle with slow and unreliable internet connections, making video streaming a challenging task.
4. Awareness of Features: Many rural users may not be fully aware of YouTube's features, such as offline viewing or content filtering options. Improved user education and awareness are essential.

Interviewer: Please go ahead.

Candidate: Absolutely. Since we are focusing on MVP, I will look at the most needed features that has the maximum impact & reach which are Language and Content Preferences and the Educational Needs

Interviewer: Now, let's discuss potential solutions for addressing these pain points. What's your proposal?

Candidate: My solution involves a multi-faceted approach:

I. Improved Content Recommendation Algorithm: Invest in AI and machine learning to create a recommendation system that factors in user preferences, location, language, and viewing history to provide more accurate and appealing content recommendations.
2. Localised Content Promotion: Create a dedicated section within YouTube that highlights regional and vernacular content. Employ content curators to ensure quality and relevance.
3. Local Learning Centers: Partner with local community centers, schools, and libraries in rural areas to establish YouTube Learning Centers. These centers can provide access to computers or mobile devices with internet connectivity, enabling rural users to access educational content
4. Localized Educational Content Hub: Create a dedicated section within YouTube that serves as a hub for high-quality educational content in local languages and dialects. This hub should feature content curated to meet the educational needs and preferences of rural users

Interviewer: Your solutions seem comprehensive. Would you go ahead with all of these?

Candidate: No, I will evaluate the solutions in each of the two pain points based on customer impact and its ease of implementation. After the evaluation, I will select Localized Content Promotion & Localized Educational Content Hub for MVP. These can be implemented in a short timeline and its success can be measured easily.

Product Improvement Case

Interviewer: Thank you for presenting these solutions. One question I have is, why do you think these solutions are particularly well-suited for India and may not be as effective in other countries with similar rural populations?

Candidate: That's an excellent question. The proposed solutions take into account India's specific socio-cultural and technological landscape, which sets it apart from many other countries with rural populations. First, India has a vast linguistic diversity with numerous regional languages and dialects, making localized content essential. Additionally, India's education system and curriculum may differ significantly from other countries, necessitating tailored educational content.

Interviewer: Great. Thanks for your time and all the best.

Candidate: Thank you.

Root Cause Analysis



Root Cause Analysis - I

Increased returns in an Amazon delivery centre

Interviewer: The returns in a delivery centre have gone up. What could be the reasons behind this, and how would you tackle this?

Candidate: Before diving into the analysis, I'd like to gather more information.

Interviewer: Of course, please proceed.

Candidate: Can you provide more details about the specific location where the return rate has increased, any unique characteristics or circumstances in that area that we should be aware of? Also, since when did the returns increase?

Interviewer: The increased return rate is primarily in urban Bangalore, and this trend has been noticeable over the past one to two months.

Candidate: Okay, given this information, there could be both external and internal factors contributing to the rising return rate. I'll like to explore some of the external factors.

Interviewer: That sounds like a good approach.

Candidate: (External Factors - I. Competitor Activity) Have any competitors in the area introduced new services, policies, or incentives that might be encouraging customers to return products more frequently?

Interviewer: We haven't observed any significant changes from competitors in the region.

Candidate: (2. Seasonal Trends:) Are there any seasonal factors, such as holidays or festivals, that could be affecting customer buying patterns and returns?

Interviewer: There haven't been any major seasonal events during this period.

Candidate: (3. Logistics and Delivery Issues:) Have there been any disruptions or challenges in the delivery process, like delays, damaged packages, or incorrect orders?

Interviewer: Our delivery operations have been running smoothly without any notable disruptions.

Candidate: Proceeding to some Internal Factors, (I. Product Quality) Have there been any recent issues with the quality of products being delivered in this area?

Interviewer: We've maintained our product quality standards, and there haven't been any significant quality complaints.

Candidate: (2. Customer Behaviour) Have there been any changes in customer behaviour or preferences in this specific region that might be influencing their return decisions?

Interviewer: We have noticed that customers in this area seem to be returning items even if they are in good condition, which is unusual.

Candidate: That's an interesting observation. It might be crucial to explore why customers in this region are returning items even if they are not defective.

Interviewer: Agreed, we're particularly concerned about this behaviour as it deviates

from the norm.

Candidate: To tackle this issue, I would recommend a multi-faceted approach:
Firstly, I'd like to conduct Customer Surveys or interviews with customers in the affected area to understand their reasons for returning products, even if they are in good condition. This can provide valuable insights into their motivations.

Then, use data analysis tools to analyse the return data in detail, including product categories, customer profiles, and return reasons, to identify any patterns or trends specific to this region.

It'd be important to establish a feedback loop between the delivery centre, customer service and product teams to quickly address any emerging issues and improve customer satisfaction.
We can also launch an awareness campaign to inform customers about the return policy, emphasizing that returns should be reserved for genuinely unsatisfactory or defective products.

A final suggestion would be to clearly communicate the return policy during the checkout process and on product pages, so customers are fully aware of the terms and conditions.

Interviewer: Sounds comprehensive enough. We can conclude here.

Root Cause Analysis - 2

Reduced user engagement in WhatsApp during Covid-19

Interviewer: Assume, we are currently going through a COVID Lockdown. And, we are seeing a drop in User Engagement on WhatsApp.

Candidate: Okay, do we know the magnitude of the drop and may I know how this metric is exactly measured?

Interviewer: We don't know the magnitude. A lot of factors go into the measurement of this metric. We use some stable parameters like the number of contacts of a user, average message received per day(measured over a month), etc, and compare them with short-term dynamic parameters like daily session time and number of messages sent every day.

Candidate: That's interesting. Has the method of measuring the metric changed in the recent past?

Interviewer: No it's the same, there is a definite decrease. Another piece of information I can give you is that we have actually seen an increase in DAU and MAU and the number of groups being created are also increasing significantly.

Candidate: Thank you for the information. Have we observed this drop in a particular geography? And over what duration has it been observed? Are there any significant external events that could have affected our metric?

Interviewer: The drop is mainly being observed in Tier-I cities. Apart from this, there is nothing relevant to us.

Candidate: Got it. As it's lockdown, Mobile and Social Media usage must have gone up recently which would explain the increase in DAU and MAU. I'd like to now analyse if there were any app changes. Broadly we can list out the tasks that can be performed as messaging,calling and sending and receiving media in group and personal chats, putting up statuses and profile pictures, creating and managing groups and broadcast channels. Is there any specific journey I should focus on? Also, have there been any recent updates?

Interviewer: There have been no updates We're not seeing any particular irregularities in any of these user journeys in terms of usage.

Candidate: Okay, then maybe I would like to probe into the possibility of changed user behaviour. As suggested by the calculations of the metric and the data about increasing number of groups, an initial estimate is that users are not engaging with all the groups as they would earlier because they are getting overwhelmed. Another possibility could be that we are seeing a lot of broadcast messages for help because of COVID and these could be getting ignored unless somebody has the resources to help.

Interviewer: You got it right. Too many groups are being formed in the lockdown and users are archiving and muting groups because they don't want to be spammed. How would you propose to solve this?

Candidate: Sure, a balanced solution will be tricky because we can't disincentivize users if they make groups as that is also a part of user engagement. I can think of one immediate and one long-term solution. We can consider changing our current metric measurement

Root Cause Analysis - 2

temporarily to account for the edge-case scenario we are currently going through. In the long run, to decrease the frustration that groups might cause, we can add high levels of customization that the user can make for what they want to see in their feed. If someone doesn't want to be a part of a group, they usually leave it, but if they are in the group there is some value that they are deriving from it or some obligation that they have to fulfill. These could include:

I) Adding word filters for alerts (Send notification when "birthday" appears in chat)

2)adding alerts based on attributes like frequ--ency (Send notification when message rate goes over 3/minute for 5 minutes which would indicate an active conversation that the user might want to be a part of it)

3)Enable anonymous feedback for forwarded messages so that the sender knows how their messages are being received and curate messages in the future

Interviewer: These sound good to me. We can end the interview here. Thanks.

Candidate: Thank you!

Root Cause Analysis - 3

Drop in movie bookings in BookMyShow

Interviewer: Let's dive right in. We've recently experienced a significant drop in movie booking transactions on the BookMyShow app over a weekend. Bookings were down by 70% compared to the previous weekend. Find out why this is happening.

Candidate: To better analyse the root cause of this drop in bookings, I'd like to gather some additional information.

Interviewer: Certainly. Please proceed with your questions.

Candidate: Firstly, can you provide me with the exact timeline for when the drop in bookings occurred?

Interviewer: This drop was in the middle of last month

Candidate: Can you specify the geographical region where this drop was observed? Is it limited to a particular city or country?

Interviewer: The drop in bookings was observed across India.

Candidate: Okay. Is this drop in bookings consistent across both iOS, Android platforms & web, or more pronounced on one platform?

Interviewer: The drop is consistent across all platforms.

Candidate: Can you provide me with any insights into the marketing campaigns or promotions that were running during the affected weekend?

Interviewer: Yes, we had a special promotion for movie bookings during that whole month, offering a flat ₹100 discount on all tickets.

Candidate: That's a decent discount. Do we have any information on theatre occupancy rate whether it declined or not during the specified time?

Interviewer: Yes, there was a decline over that weekend but not a significant amount, there was a decline of 15%.

Candidate: Can you confirm if there were any app updates, server downtime, or maintenance activities during the affected weekend?

Interviewer: Yes, there was minor update of the site and app over the weekend.

Candidate: Following the user journey, one needs to log in to their account. Are there any known issues with the login process thus causing delays or preventing login?

Interviewer: No, the login process has been functioning normally during affected period.

Candidate: The user searches for a movie and selects a show time and seats. Are there any issues with the search functionality or the availability of movie listings?

Interviewer: The search functionality is working properly, and there are no major issues with movie listings.

Candidate: Once the user has selected their movie and seats, they proceed to the checkout page. Are there any issues with the checkout process itself, such as payment gateways or payment processing?

Root Cause Analysis - 3

Interviewer: Payment gateways and payment processing have been functioning smoothly during the affected period.

Candidate: Finally, at the checkout page, the user is prompted to enter the promo code to avail the offer which was rolled out this month. This is where user might have issue with applying the discount.

Interviewer: Yes, that's correct. Users are unable to enter or apply the promo code, preventing them from availing the discount.

Candidate: Therefore, the inability to apply the promo code seems to be the root cause of the drop in movie booking transactions. Users are likely abandoning their bookings if they can't avail the discount they were expecting.

Interviewer: What steps would you recommend to address it promptly?

Candidate: I suggest prioritizing the resolution of the promo code field's responsiveness issue. This may involve a quick bug fix or update to the app.

Interviewer: That's a comprehensive approach. Thank you.

Root Cause Analysis - 4

Fall in Disney Subscription

Interviewer: You are a product manager for Disney. For the past one month, we have seen a decline in the number of new subscription renewals.

Candidate: Got it. Just to confirm, by renewals, we mean the ratio of accounts renewed to total activated accounts? Also, did we see the drop across all subscription plans? Is it specific to a particular region? Is it across all devices?

Interviewer: Yes you are correct about renewals. Our new subscriptions are also going down. We have seen the drop across all plans and devices and all over India.

Candidate: Okay I'll take a minute before going ahead. I'd like to start with the external and internal causes and further break them down into different categories. With external, I'd consider the macroeconomic factors and competitors. With Internal, I'd like to consider Technology, User Journeys, and Business Strategies.

Interviewer: Sounds good. Let's start with external first.

Candidate: So considering macro factors first, are there any regulatory or legal constraints introduced on the platform? Or has there been any sort of negative PR with respect to our platform?

Interviewer: No, nothing of this sort has happened. Let's move ahead.

Candidate: Fair. Thinking about competition, do we have any new players in the market where people have shifted to or any modifica-tions in our competitors' pricing and offerings?

Interviewer: Nothing significant. Let's see what we have in internal categories.

Candidate: Sure. Do you want me to focus on any one of the categories I listed, technology, user journeys and strategies?

Interviewer: Let's see what a user journey looks like.

Candidate: There are two possible journeys here. One includes the process of renewing the plan and second is using the Disney platform for content. The first journey starts with going to profile > clicking renew/ subscribe > choosing plan > selecting payment method > making payment.
The second journey includes login > searching for content > ads (depends on plan) > watching the content > interacting with features like quality/ subtitles/ language/ next episode > and finally exiting the platform.

Interviewer: Impressive. When you talked about plans, what all is included in the offerings?

Candidate: Some of the features we cover are ads, no. of screens, audio/ video qualities.

Interviewer: Not features. Based on what offerings will a customer subscribe to us?

Candidate: I think the price point, content on platform and in case of disney, rights to host sports tournaments are some of the offerings.

Interviewer: You are right. Our content library has changed and we need fresh options for our users. That's all from my end. Thank you.

Root Cause Analysis - 5

Decrease in New Bank Accounts

Interviewer: A major bank in India has been seeing a sudden decrease in the opening of new bank accounts. What do you think could be the reasons behind this and how would you address the problem?

Candidate: Okay, just to make sure that I have understood the question correctly, there is a reduction in the number of people opening newer bank accounts in the bank. Are we focusing on the digital way of opening bank accounts or in branches?

Interviewer: Yes, you are correct. We are focusing on the digital way of opening bank accounts.

Candidate: Okay, before I proceed with the analysis, I want to request some additional details regarding the same.

Interviewer: Yes, please go ahead.

Candidate: Since how long are we facing this problem? Are we seeing a sudden decline in the new bank accounts?

Interviewer: We have been facing this problem for the past 3 months and yes, we have been seeing a sudden decline in opening of new bank accounts.

Candidate: Is this problem related to specific branches or locations? Are there any specific customer segments or account types that seem to be more affected?

Interviewer: No, this isn't related to any specific location or branch as such. We have been facing this problem all over India and the decline has been noted across all kinds of individual and business bank accounts.

Candidate: Okay, thank you for the information. Given these details, several factors may contribute to the decrease. I'll begin by exploring potential external factors.

Interviewer: Okay, sounds like a good approach, please go ahead.

Candidate: Have there been any recent economic changes or uncertainties that might impact people's decision to open new bank accounts?

Interviewer: No, nothing as such, the economic conditions have remained relatively stable in India and there haven't been any significant changes.

Candidate: Have there been new offerings or promotions from competing banks attracting potential customers away from our bank?

Interviewer: We haven't noticed any major changes in competitor offerings that would explain the decline.

Candidate: Has the banking sector undergone any recent regulatory changes that could impact the account opening procedure?

Interviewer: No noteworthy regulatory modifications have been made that could affect the account opening procedure.

Candidate: Okay, it seems that there are no major external factors affecting the decline in new bank accounts as of now. I want to ask a few questions related to internal factors. Is it fine?

Interviewer: Sure, proceed.

Root Cause Analysis - 5

Candidate: Have there been any bug reports or technical faults associated with the customers digital onboarding? Are we seeing the decline in mobile application or website as well?

Interviewer: No, our digital onboarding process has been considered efficient and we haven't reported any technical glitches as such. We are seeing the decline with mobile applications.

Candidate: Have there been any changes in our marketing strategies or campaigns related to promoting new account openings? Have we introduced any new privacy policy?

Interviewer: No, we have continued with our regular marketing strategies, and we haven't made any changes to the privacy policy.

Candidate: Is there any feedback or data suggesting a decline in overall customer experience during the account opening process? Have we introduced any updates to the mobile application that might be affecting smoother user navigation?

Interviewer: Yes, we have launched a new update for the mobile application, and it might be a valid consideration. What would be your recommendations for the problem?

Candidate: Sure, these can be the recommendations according to me.

- Conduct an in-depth analysis of customer feedback related to the account opening process to identify pain points and areas for improvement.
- Collaborate with the operations team to streamline and improve the experience of the account opening procedure.
- Develop an interactive onboarding tutorial that guides users through key features and functionalities when they first launch the application. This can help users understand how to navigate and use the app effectively.
- Ensure that the navigation menu is clear, organized, and easy to understand. Use familiar icons and labels to represent different sections or features of the application. Consider implementing a straightforward hierarchy that aligns with user expectations.

Interviewer: Thank you for the insights and recommendations.

Candidate: Thank you

Root Cause Analysis - 6

Falling PhonePe Transactions

Interviewer: We are seeing a 12% drop in transactions on Phonepe. Please try to find out the possible root cause.

Candidate: When we say transactions, do we mean the value of the transactions or the number of Total transactions? Also over what period was the drop observed?

Interviewer: It is a drop in the number of Total transactions and it has been observed over the past 2 weeks.

Candidate: Okay 12% over 2 weeks seems significant. Does the data suggest any major variations in this drop across operating systems or across user categories?

Interviewer: Can you elaborate on what you mean by user categories?

Comment: Interviewer may be indicating that you're trying to get answers from the panelist by asking such broad questions instead of getting to them yourself

Candidate: Sure, I mean that higher deviations could be observed in a specific category that might be relevant to this metric. I) Old users vs Newly onboarded users which can give us an indication about a buggy app version 2) Geographic Categories. A drop in a specific city can indicate abnormal social conditions in that area

Interviewer: Okay, fair enough. The drop has been observed uniformly across Platforms and the categories you mentioned.

Candidate: Has Phonepe or its major competitors like GPay and PayTM had any new PR campaigns, ads, or promotion strategies in the recent past that have gathered unusual attention?

Interviewer: Nothing significant. In fact, Google Pay has witnessed higher-than-normal growth in their transactions

Candidate: Have we had any major updates recently?

Interviewer: Yes, we did roll out an update two weeks ago. We didn't make any changes to the UI, but fixed some bugs. We started noticing the decline after this update.

Candidate: Then I'd like to chart out the user journey and try to pinpoint sources of pain points.
In Phonepe there are multiple ways to make a transaction. To initiate a transaction you can either scan a QR code, enter a phone number, or enter the UPI ID. There are also other functionalities like payment using bank details but I think I can rule that out considering the problem statement only talks about UPI transactions. Are we seeing any drops in these individual user journeys?

Interviewer: No we haven't seen a significant drop in these particular Journeys. Do you think you missed out on any other way to make payments?

Candidate: Oh yes I completely missed third-party app transactions using Phonepe. Usually, when we want to purchase something on an app, after adding it to the cart we proceed to payment. Then we see the various payment options that are available to us. If we want to pay using Phonepe we select the option post which we get a notification saying "This app has requested X amount on

Root Cause Analysis - 6

Phonepe". We can click on the notification and click pay within the popup that PhonePe gives us. We enter the UPI pin, the transaction gets completed and we get redirected back to the third-party app

Interviewer: Yes, actually, we are seeing a drop in transactions in this channel. We found that In the update we rolled out which was aimed at fixing the bugs that we reported in the previous period a new bug was introduced where users were not able to see the popup and hence would abandon transactions. They then switch to other apps like Google Pay which is why they are seeing an increase in transactions.
Great, we can conclude here then.

Candidate: Thank you for the opportunity.

Root Cause Analysis - 7

Returns Increase of Nykaa

Interviewer: Order returns at Nykaa have been up by almost 20% for the past 2 weeks can you help us diagnose what may be happening.

Candidate: Surely, but before I start I would like to clarify some things. Since Nykaa has both Fashion & Beauty in its portfolio have we seen this trend in any specific segment or all across?

Interviewer: We have been seeing this trend for Nykaa Beauty across all beauty segments.

Candidate: Are we seeing this spike on any specific platform like the web or app, Android or Apple?

Interviewer: Our majority of sales occur through mobile applications so we do see a jump across the mobile app which gives users greater functionality & features.

Candidate: Is there any specific segment of users like age group or gender that has led to this increase?

Interviewer: We have a high percentage of female users & the issue seems to persist across all demographics within the beauty segment.

Candidate: are we concerned about order cancellations both before & after this 2-week window?

Interviewer: No, the cancellation rates have come down after this particular 2-week period but you can consider a week before & after as your scope.

Comment: Interviewer may be indicating that you're trying to get answers from the panelist by asking such broad questions instead of getting to them yourself

Candidate: Ok, understood, has there been any change in the competitive landscape of the beauty e-commerce industry or any kind of macro-factor that may have affected us?

Interviewer: Can you elaborate on what you mean by macro factors?

Candidate: Yeah sure, I mean has there been any legal change, political movement or social media wave that may have affected consumers' perception & habits concerning the brand?

Interviewer: No there have been no macro-environment changes that can affect the returns in such a way & the competitive landscape has been stable enough.

Candidate: Understood & have our other competitors faced the same issue for returns increasing?

Interviewer: or now it seems this issue is specifically affecting Nykaa.

Candidate: Ok so it seems that the root cause lies within Nykaa & not due to the external environment around us.

Interviewer: Yes, it is fair to say that the issue lies within our walls.

Candidate: Has there been any new strategy, scheme, marketing, or sale in these past few weeks or is there a sale about to happen that may prompt users to return their products in the hope of discounts later on?

Root Cause Analysis - 7

Interviewer: Good thinking, we do see some spikes during the sales season or when we give seasonal discounts but none would explain such a high jump in returns, but there have been no major strategic initiatives during this time.

Candidate: Has there been any major application update both technical or on the front end during this period?

Interviewer: We had a bug-fixing update during the spike & another with technical & UX changes I week before the spike.

Candidate: Can you tell me what the Technical-UX, bug-fixing updates included?

Interviewer: The major upgrade had some minor UI tweaks that had no impact on the customer flow but we did upgrade our Augmented Reality tool in the upgrade which allows the customer to see how the products would look on them in real-time

Candidate: Can you tell me how the AR Tool works & its value to the customer?

Comment: Just like in this case if you do not know what exactly a particular feature is or how it adds value do not hesitate to ask your Interviewer, it's better to have your doubts clarified than be exposed later on

Interviewer: So the AR tool is something Nykaa built in-house to allow our customers to see how the specific product would look on them & the update allowed it to work in different lighting conditions so the customer can see how the product looks in real life which was very well received by our customers.

Comment: The interviewer could have also asked at the start if there was a jump in the orders placed as well which could have led to arriving here quicker.

Candidate: Has the AR tool been working as expected or have there been some issues with the tool?

Interviewer: The AR tool has been working quite well in internal testing but we do seem to have some complaints from customers that the color of the products is not a perfect replica in real life.

Candidate: Could the bug in the AR Tool be the reason for the increased product returns?

Interviewer: It could be but how would you explain the time lag between the launch of the AR Tool & the spike of cancellations?

Candidate: Delivery time! When the feature was launched people started ordering the products on what they saw in the AR Filter but after a week or so when they got the product in their hands they realized it was not the same color as in the app, so they returned it. I would assume that the bug fixing update took care of the issue hence the spike dropped.

Interviewer: Great! That's exactly what happened, our team caught the mistake & rolled the fix soon. We can conclude this RCA here.

Candidate: Thank you so much for the opportunity.

Comment: This RCA is unique in the sense that we have to consider the lag between the app update, fix & the delivery time which makes it seem that the issue & updates are not in sync & occur on 2 separate timelines.

Root Cause Analysis - 8

Spotify session time is decreasing

Interviewer: Consider yourself as the product manager at Spotify. Currently, Spotify is experiencing a decrease in the session time. Find out the root cause of this issue.

Candidate: Just to make sure that I understood the problem statement correctly, I would like to reiterate it. So, Spotify's session time is decreasing, and I'm here to find out why. So, what exactly is session time? Is it the average time spent by the users in the app?

Interviewer: Yes, that's exactly what session time is.

Candidate: Before I dive in, I want to know some more specific information. Is this issue globally prevalent, or is it there in any specific regions?

Interviewer: This is not exactly geography-specific, but this issue is a little high in some regions. But for this case, you can ignore the geography.

Candidate: Oh, ok. I would not be considering the geography right now. But what about the platform? Is it platform-specific?

Interviewer: Yes, this issue is only present in the mobile and especially in the Android segment.

Candidate: Great, and how about the divide between free and premium users? Is the issue prevalent between both customers?

Interviewer: Yes, this is common between both customers.

Candidate – OK, Now I can divide the possible causes into 2 ways, one is internal changes in the company or the application that has caused this issue. And the other is the external causes. Let me start with the external causes. Was there any new competition or new price change from the competitor side?

·**Interviewer:** No, the competition remains the same. You can safely ignore the external factors and proceed with the internal factors.

Candidate: OK, so has Spotify made any changes to the application? Were there any UI changes or any major updates?

Interviewer: Yes, there was an update that introduced a feature to browse and play media on the phone's local storage.

Candidate: To track where the problem occurs, I would like to draw out a user journey specifically for this feature. So, initially, I hope the login doesn't change. Then the user would be opening the app every time they use it. Once they open it, they would be going to the locally stored files, for which they would require storage permission. Is the Storage permission granted? And is the problem specific to any of the steps of the user journey mentioned above?

Interviewer: The Storage permission is not an issue here, and there is no specific problem in any of the steps of the user journey, the whole application is crashing frequently.

Candidate: Oh, the main problem is that the application crashes frequently, and users cannot use the application for a longer duration, which in turn decreases the total session time. So, shall I dive deep into the root cause of this crashing?

Root Cause Analysis - 8

·**Interviewer:** Yes go ahead.

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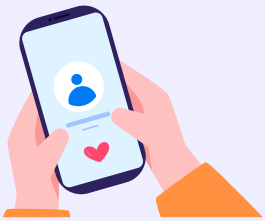
Candidate: Since you have mentioned that the issue is prevalent only on the Android segment and then here there are crashes, one of my guesses is that the lower-end segment users of Android phones are experiencing this issue, and their phones are not able to support the newer updates as they would be requiring more power and storage. Is this correct?

Interviewer: Yes you are right, due to the addition of this functionality the size of the app increased. In turn, it affected lower-end Android phones in which the app started to crash hence decreasing the user engagement for that particular user base. Great work!

App Critique



App Critique Theory







An App Critique entails analyzing design choices, sharing your objective opinions, and providing constructive feedback about a given app. This is a way for interviewers to evaluate your product thinking, user experience, visual and interaction design skills, communication skills, and ability to give feedback.

A basic framework such as the one below can be kept in mind when facing app critique interviews.

- What is the App's Value Proposition?
- Who are the Target audiences of the App?
- Identify the app's features and user flows, focusing on the impact of the selected feature on the company's business and user problems. Assess whether the feature contributes to user acquisition, retention, engagement, etc., and how it aligns with the company's business model. Explore whether the feature encourages users to invest money or time in the app.

We can also use the Standard Usefulness, Efficiency, Innovativeness and Improvements framework to perform app critiques. Before delving into app analysis, give a little brief about the Product's value proposition, their business model and target audience. The aim here is to give a precursor to what is the value that the users derive from the product.

Common app critique mistakes to avoid during interviews:

- **Focusing on aesthetics over functionality:** It's easy to get caught up in pointing out visual flaws in the UI. Aesthetics alone won't matter if the app fails to fulfill its core purpose.
- **Rigidity in Approach**: If you've pre-selected an app for critique, be prepared to adapt your approach based on the interviewer's prompts. Display flexibility and a willingness to consider various methods.
- **Superficial praise without substance:** Overwhelmingly positive comments may indicate an inability to analyze the work critically. Demonstrate ability to identify both strengths and weaknesses for a more well-rounded assessment.
- **Overemphasis on UI Description:** Spending too much time describing the UI without delving into the reasoning behind your observations can be a pitfall. Interviewers are interested in your thought process, not a laundry list of UI elements.

Explore what makes certain aspects effective or ineffective. Employing a structured critique framework helps maintain objectivity and guides your evaluation. Additionally, consider comparing the app in question with similar apps.

App Critique I

Splitwise

Value Proposition:
Splitwise is a financial management app designed to simplify and streamline the process of splitting expenses among friends, family, roommates, or colleagues. Its primary value proposition lies in easing the complexities of shared expenses, ensuring transparency, and promoting fairness in financial transactions among groups.

Business Model
Splitwise operates on a freemium business model, offering both free and paid premium services to its users.

Target Audience
The App is mainly targeted towards users who want to track their shared expenses during a trip, vacation etc., Also it is highly beneficial for people living together in rented accommodations, Students etc.,

Major needs of these users include:

- To Effortlessly track expenses with friends during outings, eliminating the need to deal with bill-splitting and calculation hassles.
- To Avoid forgetting shared expenses to prevent confusion

Comment: Try to relate to the needs of user personas rather than your own views. You're going to be designing products for users and not for yourself, so make sure to keep personal biases aside, and analyze how the app is solving user's problems.
Usefulness:

- Splitwise follows a minimalistic but effective UI which does the job with consistent and simple use of colours.
- Expense Management: Captures expenses with detailed information, including date of transaction, custom notes, and even adds scanned bill receipts (Splitwise pro feature)- Extremely useful when you refer back to track your expenses after a while.
- Splitwise provides flexible bill splitting options like splitting expenses equally, Manual allocation, Percentage, Add/subtract share amount etc. It is extremely useful when you want to play around with how you want to share the expenses among your group.
- Group Options: Making groups with frequently contacted persons is an extremely useful feature as it simplifies the expense management and bill splitting process. Also it provides additional features like charts and currency conversion (Splitwise Pro features), Spending summary of group etc.
- The "Settling Up" feature simplifies calculations so people can easily track individual expenses.

Efficiency:

- The bright, green "+" button for adding expenses is easily discoverable and enhances accessibility.
- All main functionalities such as Friends, groups, Activity are neatly listed on the home page, ensuring a simple and straightforward user experience.

Innovativeness:

- "Simplify Debts" feature minimizes transactions and avoids confusion. It is extremely innovative and helpful in avoiding excessive transactions. It does not change the total amount that anyone owes, but it makes it easier to pay people back by minimizing the total number of payments. The option to turn it on/off is a plus.
- Splitwise Pro's innovative features like

App Critique I

scanned bill receipts and currency conversion enhance user experience.

Improvements:

- The home page can be made less cluttered by removing “settle up” information and allowing users to navigate to the required buttons to view them.
- Lack of payment verification in ”Settle Up” can lead to discrepancies in verifying the authenticity of payments. As the pending payments are converted to settled on based on any one stakeholder’s input. Implement verification feature for ”Settle Up” payments. Feature to ensure that both parties agree before balances are settled. Admin feature: In such cases, the user who creates the group can be made an admin who can approve transactions in cases where users in the group settle a payment.
- A possible solution to Increase discoverability of “Simplify debts” can be to place the feature next to the group name, providing users with ease of access to this functionality.

Possible Additional features that can be added:

- Integration with other apps: Currently Splitwise does not provide payment option within the app. Splitwise has the potential to broaden its user base significantly by integrating with popular digital payment platforms such as Google Pay and Paytm (Paytm integration unavailable for ios) etc., Collaborating with other widely-used digital products like BookMyShow, Goibibo, MakeMyTrip, Zomato/Swiggy, and similar booking platforms could further enhance the user experience
- Reminder to settle debts: A reminder notification to all the concerned people to settle their debts by a particular date is needed. This feature can be enabled at the group level as well, making sure users remember to repay their debts, one group at a time.

Comment: Check with the Interviewer and try to summarize the whole critique at the end of the Interview.

Summarizing the critique, Splitwise excels in user-friendly expense management, offering a minimalistic UI with effective use of colors. Its flexible bill splitting options and group features simplify expense tracking. However, the lack of payment verification in ”Settle Up” can lead to discrepancies. The app’s innovative ”Simplify Debts” feature minimizes transactions but could improve discoverability. Potential improvements include a less cluttered home page and the addition of features like payment integration with popular platforms and debt settlement reminders.

App Critique 2

Slack

Value Proposition:
Slack is a team collaboration platform designed to simplify communication and enhance productivity in professional settings. Its primary value proposition lies in providing a centralized and organized space for team communication, file sharing, and collaboration, ultimately reducing the reliance on scattered emails and improving overall workflow efficiency.

Business Model:
Slack operates on a freemium business model, offering both free and paid premium services to its users. The premium services include advanced features such as unlimited message history, advanced app integrations, and greater storage capacity.
Target Audience:
The app is targeted towards businesses and teams of various sizes seeking a more efficient and organized way to communicate and collaborate. It caters to professionals in different industries who need a centralized platform for real-time communication and file sharing.

Major needs of these users include:

- Efficient team communication without the clutter of emails.
- Centralized storage and easy retrieval of shared files and documents.
- Seamless integration with other productivity tools.

Usefulness

- Slack employs a clean and modern UI with a predominantly white and purple color scheme. The design is intuitive, with channels, direct messages, and apps prominently displayed on the sidebar for easy navigation.
- The clean and organized layout ensures a user-friendly experience.
- The threaded conversation feature helps maintain context within discussions.

Efficiency

- File sharing and collaboration: Enables users to share documents, images, and other files seamlessly within the platform, also the button placements are efficient to use
- App integrations: Allows integration with a wide range of third-party apps to streamline workflows. Slack seamlessly integrates with top apps like JIRA, Clockwise, Google Drive, Zendesk, Dropbox, and GitHub. With over 1,500 apps available in its directory, Slack provides extensive integration options.
- Clear notification system for messages and mentions, reducing the chances of missing important information.

Innovativeness:

- **Channel-based communication:** Provides a structured way for teams to communicate based on topics or projects. The Thread feature in Slack is useful. It lets you continue different conversations in separate threads, reducing clutter and making it less likely to miss important messages.
- **Search feature:** Slack keeps everything in one place so you don't lose info. It saves messages with time stamps, tracks shared files, and helps you find stuff easily with a smart search system. It scores better than competitor apps like teams in this area.

Improvements:

- The "Do Not Disturb" feature might be ignored due to low discoverability, leading

App Critique 2

- to potential disruptions during focused work periods. Visibility can be enhanced, perhaps with a more prominent icon or notification.
- Provide more granular controls over notification preferences to allow users to customize their alert settings further.
- The learning curve for new users can be steep due to the multitude of features, but the guide/help feature can be improved.

Possible Features That Can Be Added:

- Interactive calendar integration: A feature allowing users to schedule and manage meetings directly within the Slack platform.
- Screen Sharing feature does not work on tablets or smartphones. This feature is a must need and can be introduced for android and IoS.
- Enhanced analytics: Introduce more robust analytics tools for team leaders to track communication patterns and productivity metrics.
- Summarizing the critique, Slack excels in providing a robust communication and collaboration platform, but potential improvements lie in UI customization, onboarding, and enhanced notification controls. Additionally, exploring new features such as interactive calendars and advanced analytics could further elevate the user experience.

App Critique 3

PhonePe

Value Proposition:
PhonePe is a mobile payment and financial services platform that aims to simplify digital transactions and provide users with a seamless and secure way to manage their finances. Its primary value proposition lies in offering a one-stop solution for various financial needs, including peer-to-peer payments, bill payments, recharges, and online shopping, all within a user-friendly mobile app.

Business Model:
PhonePe operates on a digital wallet and UPI-based payment model, allowing users to link their bank accounts for easy transactions. The app generates revenue through transaction fees and partnerships with merchants. Additionally, PhonePe offers various financial products like insurance and mutual funds, contributing to its revenue stream.

Target Audience:
The app targets a broad audience, including individuals who prefer the convenience of digital payments, online shoppers, and those seeking easy access to financial services through their smartphones.
Major needs of these users include:

- Convenient and secure digital payment options.
- Efficient bill payment and recharge facilities.

Usefulness

- PhonePe features a vibrant and intuitive UI with a purple and white color scheme. Tweaking the logo to imitate INR is very intuitive.
- The design is user-friendly, with essential features like money transfer, recharge, and bill payments prominently displayed on the home screen.
- Clear and straightforward navigation for core services. All major features such as credit, Insurance and basic payment features are easily discoverable in the home page.
- Integration of various financial services such as insurance, mutual investments etc in one app is very useful.
- Clear transaction history and details for users to track their spending.

Efficiency:

- Peer-to-peer payments: Enables users to send and receive money seamlessly using UPI or digital wallets.
- Bill payments and recharges: Allows users to pay bills, recharge mobile phones, and top up DTH services directly through the app.

Innovativeness:

- Financial products: Offers services like insurance and mutual funds for users looking to invest or manage their finances.
- PhonePe Switch: This feature allows users to seamlessly switch between multiple apps such as swiggy, makemytrip etc., from within phonepe, simplifying transaction management and purchases.
- Check Credit score:The 'Credit' section enables users to view their credit bureau score without any additional cost. This is an innovative feature and Phonepe has pioneered it among its competitor UPI Apps.

Improvements:

- Introduce a feature for group payments or bill splitting, catering to users who often share expenses with friends or family.
- In-app tutorials or guides for users

App Critique 3

- unfamiliar with certain financial products. As basic users might be able to benefit from these guides.

Possible Features That Can Be Added:

- Expense tracking: A feature that allows users to categorize and track their expenses for better financial management. Dashboards such as pie graphs showing the expense segregation, investments, savings, etc can be helpful.

Possible Features That Can Be Added:

- Integration with loyalty programs:

Collaborate with merchants to integrate loyalty programs, offering users additional benefits for transactions within the app(Similar to Gpay).

Summarizing the critique:

- PhonePe excels in providing a convenient and secure platform for digital payments and financial services. Potential improvements include enhancing educational features, introducing group expense management.

App Critique 4

Flipkart (Mobile App)

Flipkart is an Indian e-commerce giant, founded in 2007. It started as an online bookstore but has since expanded to become a leading online marketplace offering a wide range of products, from electronics and fashion to groceries and furniture.
Flipkart's value offering is a wide variety of products at a cheap price, with convenience as their priority. Currently, they have expanded their portfolio to traveling search engine via Flipkart hotels, grocery shopping through flipkart grocery and online pharmacy i.e. flipkart health plus.

Revenue streams :
Commisions:

- Flipkart makes a percentage cut whenever someone sells their product to a customer. Commissions are usually deducted from the original transaction value prior to paying out the seller who sold the item.

Shopping fees (Flipkart plus program):

- Flipkart Plus is a subscription program offered by Flipkart that provides members with various benefits and privileges to enhance their online shopping experience through super coins, exclusive offers, free delivery etc.

Own shipping subsidiary – Ekart:

- It is a department that makes all the deliveries of goods to the concerned consumer.
- Flipkart also makes money using Ekart to ship products of other retailers who have customers in India but lack logistical capabilities.

Paid ads :

The e-commerce giant has been generating a lot of money from paid ads since. It launched a digital ads platform in 2015, which attracted businesses quickly.

App analysis :
UI design :
The 'brand'switch, at the top of the home page is ambiguous to say the least. The functional implications of that button are not being communicated to the users. Only on closer observation, it can be found that the rolling banner is to denote the 'brand' attributes.
The search button within the search bar works as a good affordance for the search bar. For an organization, as established as flipkart, they are bound to focus on the monetization. This is at play here, which displays series of paid ads for products taking up almost half a page of the screen when app is opened. The rest of the page is occupied by all the new promotions of flipkart.
Only after further scrolling in home page, other products are visible. It's a safe assumption to make, that flipkart are aggressively promoting their newer revenue streams. It's not an easy task for the users to go around, when the core business starts of e commerce site getting overshadowed in the home page.
The interesting observation in search page is that, there's a section to display the recommended products based on history with bigger emphasize on image of product and the title below.
But the recommended section itself is below another section called related searches which includes sponsored products related to the search. Here promotion is placed over user convenience. The related searches section has irregular gaps in it with unutilized uneven spaces.

App Critique 4

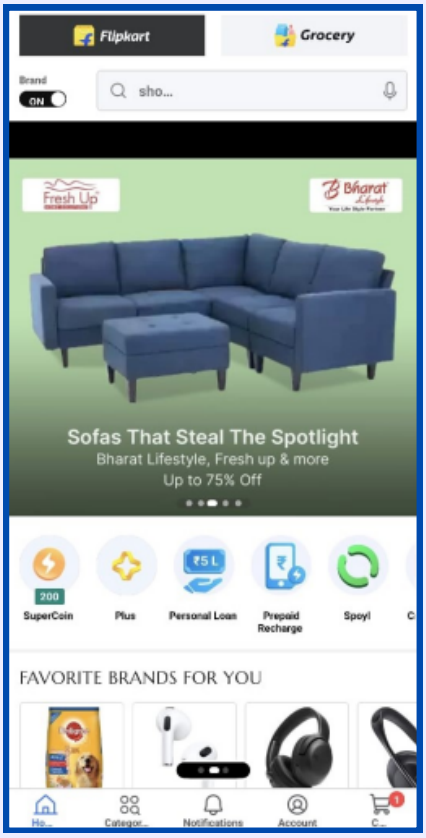


Figure: Home page

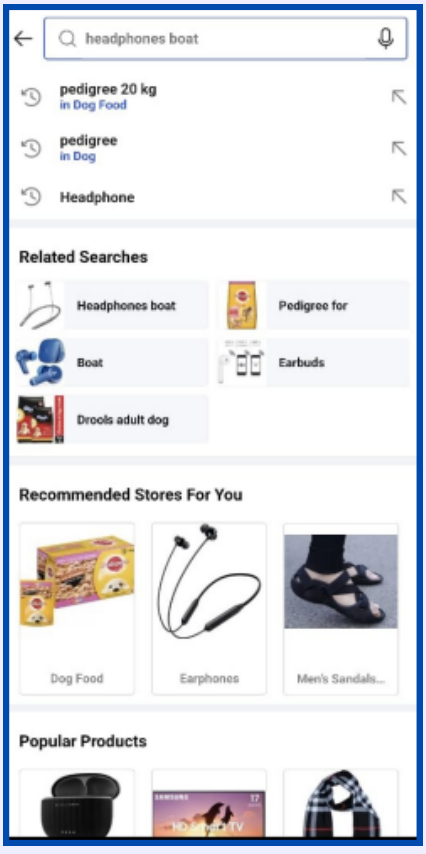


Figure: Search page

Usefulness :

The flipkart grocery module is integrated into the e commerce app itself. In order to encourage the usage of grocery, the menu is placed right at the top with the other option for flipkart itself. Although, cluttery in its positioning, the menu does help in accessibility of groceries.

The product listing page has a simplistic design with emphasis only on the product with no other highlights. The different filters available by default at the top are prominently used ones, making it convenient for the user to apply them.

Efficient :

The search bar in itself is fine with the right affordances and signifiers to indicate the presence of the bar. Search history is automatically displayed one by one which can help the customers looking to do repeat purchases with a single click.

The default view of the product is the most advanced one (360 degree view), which easily enables users to exploit it so that they get the best experience possible. There is clear indication of the available models beneath the images of the product.

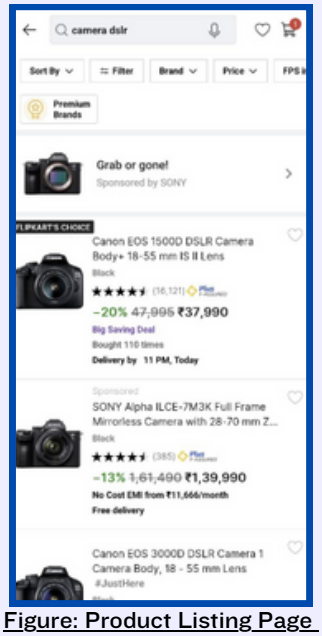


Figure: Product Listing Page

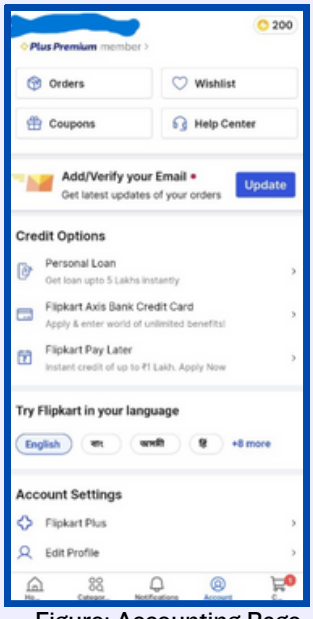


Figure: Accounting Page

App Critique 4

Innovation :

Flipkart's own AI chatbot 'flippi' is accessible from the home page with a right swipe, which has continuous animation of search suggestions being displayed. It gets more interesting with the ability to access this from any product page, wherein the chatbot will answer product specific questions.

Flipkart also aboard the 'story' trend of social media apps with the 'Vibes' section which can be accessed with a single swipe from the home page. This section promotes the products available within flipkart in form of short videos and stories similar to Instagram, with immediate access to all the products showcased in those short videos.

Improvement :

The presence of notification button in the navigation at the bottom of the page is questionable. The only function it serves is to redirect to notification page, which can be simply achieved by attaching number icons with other menu options.

Also in the search page, there is no option to remove the search history and also the presence of an 'arrow' option to the right of each search entry gives no indication of its affordances.

First listing in the product listing page at the top is a sponsored one but there's no special signifier on it, but similar position as the other listing. This may lead users directly to the sponsored product's page, which might be the goal here.

In accounts page of the app, apart from a section for basic details which looks clean, the second one is a credit offering section from flipkart which has nothing to do with the account of the user. But this is yet another example of newer promotions being put on display, an indication of flipkart's push for monetization. This page has the same issue as the 'home' page wherein crucial destined information of the respective page are overshadowed by other promotions. It can become difficult for users to navigate around in cases like this.

Since the entire product display page is very minimalistic in design with no clear visual distinction between each sections, it can be difficult for an early adopter to scroll through various information available.

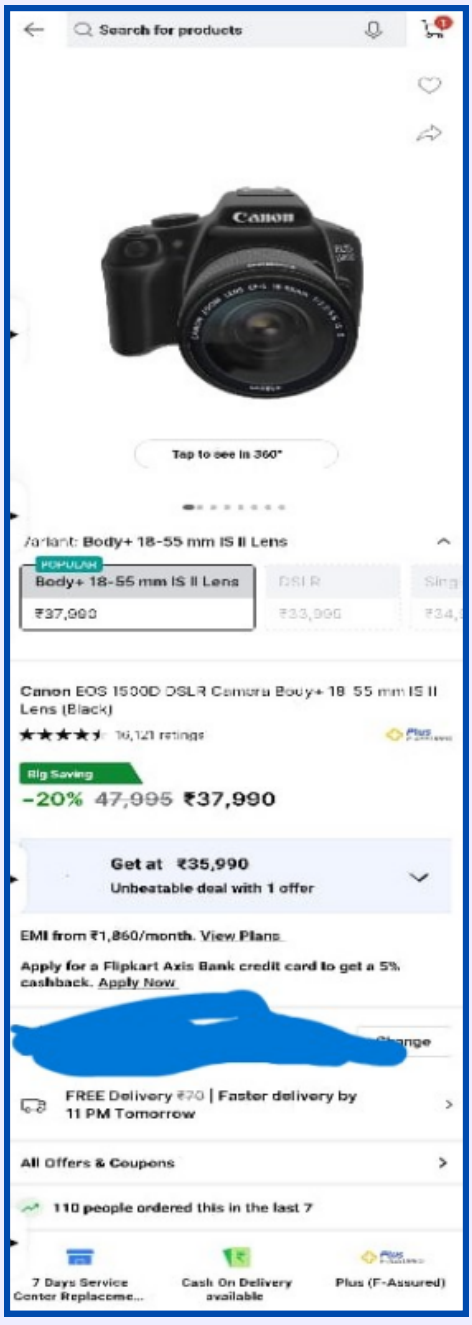


Figure: Product display page

App Critique 5

Google Calendar

Google Calendar is a widely-used online calendar and scheduling service developed by Google. It provides users with a digital platform for managing and organising their events, appointments, tasks, and reminders. It is a versatile and widely-used tool for personal and professional scheduling, offering a range of features to help users stay organised and manage their time effectively. Its integration with other Google services and its cross-platform compatibility make it a popular choice for many individuals and organisations.

Target Group:
Students, Professionals and for personal use across groups

Analysis

UX & UI Design:
Google Calendar featured a clean and uncluttered design. The UI was responsive and adapted to different screen sizes, including desktop, tablet, and mobile devices, ensuring a consistent user experience.

Usefulness:
Users can create events by specifying details such as the event title, date, time, duration, location, and description. They can also set recurring events, which is useful for daily, weekly, monthly, or custom recurring schedules. While Google Calendar primarily operates online, it offers limited offline access, allowing users to view and edit events even without an internet connection, with changes syncing once a connection is reestablished

Efficiency:
Seamless integration with other Google services, such as Gmail and Google Meet, made it convenient for users to create events and set up video conferences directly from the app. Users can share their calendars with others, enabling easy scheduling of group events or meetings. You can set permissions to control who can view, edit, or manage your calendar.

Innovation:
Few of the innovative features are that you can directly create events from Google Chat without leaving the chat and all the chat members will be added to the event as attendees. You can use Find a Time feature to schedule meetings and this smart feature would check the available slots of your attendees and suggest a suitable time. You can also leverage your Google Calendar and bookable appointment schedules for business purposes which requires payment.

Improvement:
While the app was user-friendly for those familiar with calendar apps, new users might find it slightly complex, especially when dealing with advanced features like event scheduling with multiple attendees, bookable appointments which require payments, etc. Calendar app icon always shows 31, instead it can show the current date of the month. Google Calendar is not well integrated with a few non-Google productivity tools. A new feature can be added where we can drag and drop events between days and in order to reschedule it.

App Critique 6

Zomato

Zomato is the go-to companion for all things related to food and dining, whether one is a food enthusiast looking for the latest culinary trends or a hungry individual in search of a great meal. Zomato's mission is to connect people with great food experiences, and it has become a trusted source of information and services for foodies and culinary establishments alike.

Target Group:
Families, Office going bachelors

Analysis

UI Design:
Zomato's UI featured a clean and visually appealing design with high-quality images of dishes and restaurant interiors. The app had a straightforward navigation menu that made it easy to access different sections, including Home, Explore, Orders, Bookings, and User Profile.

Usefulness:
The app excelled in helping users discover new restaurants and dining options, with advanced search filters, user reviews, ratings, and high-quality images of dishes and restaurant interiors. The app facilitated online food ordering as well as table booking with a straightforward process, including menu browsing, item selection, and secure payment options. Real-time order tracking enhanced the user experience.

Efficiency:
Zomato allows users to place orders from multiple restaurants at the same time. It also offers a mix of cash and cashless payment options. You can avail of advanced online payments options like UPI, Phonepe, Paytm, and GooglePay.

Innovation:
Zomato provides you with a feature that you can order your food online and pick it up from the restaurant by yourself. Zomato provides an option for foodies to follow their friends so that they can know what their friends eat and what they like.

Improvement:
The app's filtering and sorting options were comprehensive but could be overwhelming for some users. Enhanced localization features, including menus and descriptions in local languages, could improve accessibility for users in non-English-speaking regions. Improving offline functionality, especially for viewing saved information like menus and addresses, could benefit users in areas with limited connectivity.

App Critique 7

Spotify

Spotify is an all-in-one destination for music and audio entertainment. With its easy-to-use app, you have instant access to an extensive catalogue of songs, podcasts, and playlists from artists around the world. With a wide array of features and customization options, Spotify caters to music aficionados seeking a personalised and convenient listening experience.

Target Group:
Music lovers and enthusiasts

Analysis

UI Design:
The UI of Spotify is too cluttered with multiple playlists and suggestions and liked songs and playlists. Premium buy icon is present on the navigation tab at the bottom instead of the account icon.

Usefulness:
In some regions, you can view song lyrics in real-time as you listen, enhancing the music experience. Premium users can download songs and podcasts for offline listening. Spotify's integration of podcasts provided users with a wide range of audio content, from entertainment and education to news and storytelling.

Efficiency:
Premium users can adjust the audio quality to suit their preferences, whether they're streaming over a cellular network or using Wi-Fi. Premium users can adjust the audio quality to suit their preferences, whether they're streaming over a cellular network or using Wi-Fi

Innovation:
Spotify's algorithm creates personalised playlists like "Discover Weekly" and "Release Radar" based on your listening habits, ensuring a constantly evolving music experience. People can share their favourite songs and playlists with friends on social media or collaborate on playlists with others. People can also share their favourite songs and playlists using Spotify Code which is a generated QR code.

Improvement:
Translation of the lyrics of regional songs can be made available in English or in other languages. Recommendation lists often include songs which we have already listened to or are in our liked songs list instead of new songs. No feature to club different playlists or albums under a single catalogue and create a new playlist instead needing to add the songs individually. Users with extensive libraries of saved songs and playlists found it cumbersome to organise and manage their content effectively.

App Critique 8

Amazon Prime Video

Amazon Prime Video offers a diverse and constantly expanding selection of content, making it a go-to choice for entertainment enthusiasts. With its combination of original productions, classic titles, and user-friendly features, it provides a comprehensive streaming experience for subscribers of Amazon Prime.

Target Group:
Across all groups

Analysis

UI Design:
The UI of Amazon prime is cluttered with multiple shows/movies suggestions based on genre, languages and shows available on other platforms which are collaborating with Amazon prime video but one needs to subscribe to those platforms individually.

Usefulness:
Users could create multiple profiles within a single Amazon Prime account, allowing family members to have personalised recommendations and watchlists. Amazon Prime Video offered personalised recommendations based on a user's viewing history, preferences, and ratings, enhancing the content discovery experience. The app also offers offline download features for the online content.

Efficiency:
Amazon prime has a "Store" section in its navigation menu and its primary page will serve as a single destination from which customers can explore the entire catalogue of movies, series, and channels that can be rented or subscribed to.

Innovation:
Users could create multiple profiles within a single Amazon Prime account, allowing family members to have personalised recommendations and watchlists. The app offered parental controls to restrict access to certain content based on age appropriateness, providing a safe viewing experience for children.

Improvement:
While the app had a search bar and filters, there can be improvements in search accuracy and navigation, especially when searching for specific content. On homepage placement of the content categories is fixed and cannot be personalised as per user preferences. There can be a new feature in the parental control where parents can block certain kids shows they don't want their kids to watch. On going back and trying to rewatch the shows it takes back to the newest season catalogue instead of showing the season you were currently watching.

App Critique 9



Kindle

The Kindle app is a versatile and user-friendly platform that brings the joy of reading to a digital format. Whether you're an avid reader, student, professional, or simply looking to explore new literary horizons, the Kindle app offers a rich and customizable reading experience on a wide range of devices.

Target Group:
All book lovers

Analysis

UI Design:
The Kindle app's homepage typically featured a library view where users could see covers of their downloaded e-books and content organised in a grid or list format.

Usefulness:
Users can personalise their reading experience by adjusting font sizes, fonts, line spacing, and background colours to suit their comfort and reading conditions. Users can personalise their reading experience by adjusting font sizes, fonts, line spacing, and background colours to suit their comfort and reading conditions. The X-Ray feature provides insights into e-books by offering character profiles, important terms, and key passages, enhancing comprehension. If users own both the e-book and audiobook versions of a title, Whispersync for Voice allows them to switch between reading and listening seamlessly.

Efficiency:
The app features a built-in dictionary, allowing users to look up word definitions with a simple tap while reading. The app allows users to search for specific content within e-books and access Wikipedia for additional information without leaving the app.

Innovation:
Kindle supports text-to-speech technology, enabling users to have e-books read aloud to them, which is particularly helpful for those with visual impairments or multitasking. The X-Ray feature provides insights into e-books by offering character profiles, important terms, and key passages, enhancing comprehension. Kindle's "Popular Highlights" feature underlines text in ebooks when more than ten people have highlighted the passage. This works with a service called "OverDrive" that allows users to get free eBooks from their local library right on their Kindle if they own a library card.

Improvement:
Expanding discovery features, such as personalised book recommendations and better genre categorization, could help users discover new titles more effectively. Adding features like book clubs, discussion forums, or social sharing could foster a sense of community among readers. A large selection of books that are supposed to have audio integration, where it will read aloud as one goes through the book, either does not integrate well, or will not allow you to buy or listen to the audiobook. There are a few inconsistencies in the user interface across different platforms, suggesting the need for a more uniform experience.

Guesstimates



Guesstimate 01

Estimate the number of watch hours in a day for Disney+Hotstar.

Candidate: Just to get a better understanding, should I focus only on subscribers or free users as well? Should I focus only on India? Also do you want me to focus on a particular day from weekday/weekend?

Interviewer: Let's take into account the subscribers of India. And you can pick any day you want.

Candidate: Okay I'll take a minute to build a framework before proceeding.
I am assuming that it is a usual weekday with no seasonality or holiday, and there is no specific event like the World Cup, etc.

Comment: Critical to clarify external or situation-specific factors in such guesstimates, where users/footfall, etc. can vary and depend on multiple factors.

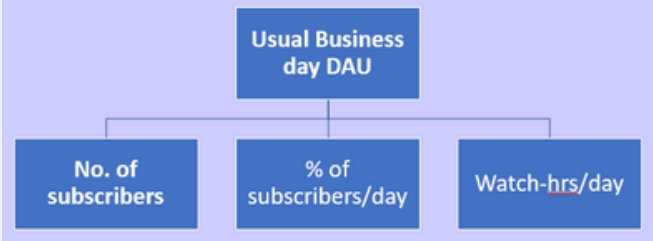
So to estimate the watch hours, I'll need:

Number of subscribers (1) x % subscribers watching disney / day (2) x average number of hours/ day (3)

Let's assume (3) as 2 hours/day. For (2), based on what I have experienced, not every subscriber uses the same platform everyday. About 2 in 5 subscribers, i.e. 40%, access Disney in a day. For (1), we can start with population, go into rural-urban splits and go further into them. Does this sound good?

Interviewer: Yes, it sounds good. Let's estimate the number of Disney subscribers.

Candidate: Assuming 1.4 billion as India's population, we can ignore the 60% rural population as our customer base, as the subscription is priced such that it targets primarily the urban population. Focusing on



the 40% urban population, we can break it down further into income groups. 40% as lower income, 50% as middle income and 10% as upper income groups. For each group we can assign factors of affordability (which considers access to internet and smartphones/ smart TVs) and penetration of disney + hotstar. Summing up these numbers will give us our subscriber base. We can multiply this with (2) and (3) mentioned previously to reach the number of watch hours per day. Do you want me to calculate the numbers for you?

Interviewer: No, this approach sounds good to me. We can leave it here. Thank you.

Guesstimate 02

Estimate the number of trainers for Haryana public school teachers

Interviewer: How many trainers would be required to train public school teachers in new ed-tech software deployed by the state government of Haryana?

Candidate: Before we begin, I would like to start by asking a few clarifying questions - Do we know the number of teachers or is that something that we need to estimate as well? What is the training duration required for the training? And, in what timeframe would we like to complete the training?

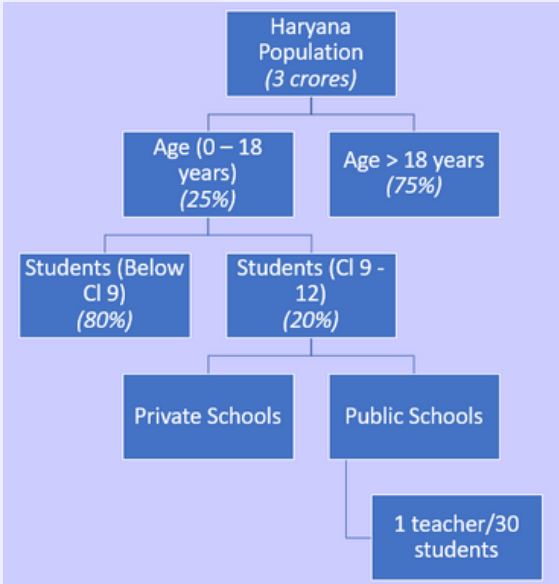
Interviewer: We need to estimate the number of teachers as well. The training will be of 4 hours spread across 2 days and we are looking to complete training for the whale state in 1 month. Also, we only need to train teachers teaching 9h class students.

Comment: Sometimes guesstimates can be two-fold, like here we calculate the number of teachers and then the trainers required. It is critical to clarify the need with the interviewer.

Candidate: Okay, thank you. I would first like to estimate the number of public school teachers in Haryana. I will start with Haryana's population, estimate the children in public schools and the number of teachers required to teach them. Does this sound fair?

Interviewer: Sure, you can go ahead.

Candidate: Considering Haryana's population to be 3 crore, 25% will be 0-18 yrs of age i.e. 75 lakhs. Of these 20% will be in classes 9-12 i.e. 15 Lakhs. Next we can consider a 2:1 split in public and private schools. This gives us 10 Lakh students in classes 9-12 in public schools. Considering a ration of 1 teacher per 30 students, we need to train 33,000 teachers.



Interviewer: This sounds fair. How will you estimate the number of trainers required?

Candidate: Assuming 1 trainer can train 10 teachers at a time and will require 2 days, he/she will train 150 teachers in a month. Thus the number of trainers required to complete training in a month will be 33,000/150 = 220

Interviewer: Great, that seems like a fair number.

Guesstimate 03

Estimate the number of messages sent in Kolkata everyday

Interviewer: A startup based out of Joka is considering selling products on WhatsApp via advertisements. Guesstimate the number of messages sent in Kolkata everyday so they may estimate the total market volume.

Candidate: Before beginning, I would like to understand the definition of a message. Do we consider it to be text or do we include any media sharing (gifs/images or video) as a part of a message?

Interviewer: Consider texts as the only form of message. Assume a text to be one message whenever the user presses the send button or hits 'enter' regardless of the length of the message.

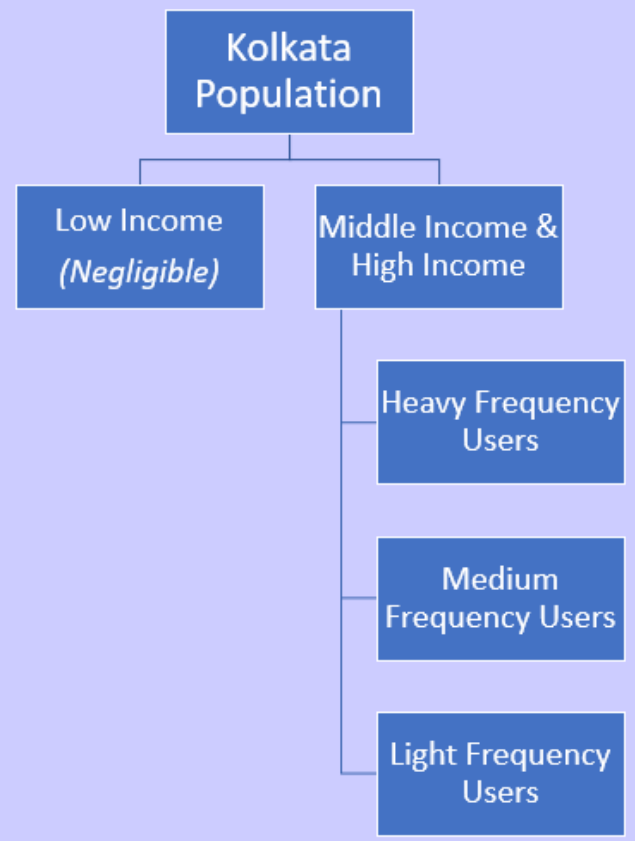
Candidate: What demographic is our startup aiming at? Will our services/ products be availed by all residents or are we looking at any specific group?

Interviewer: It would primarily be catering to the needs of adults in the age range 18-50.

Candidate: Okay. I would like to assume the population of Kolkata to be 15 million. Further I would like to divide the total number of individuals using WhatsApp by income approach. Does this sound reasonable?

Interviewer: Yes, proceed.

Candidate: I would split the population into three groups: low, middle and high income with a percentage split of 20, 50 and 30% respectively. The poor income group are assumed to not use WhatsApp. Further, since we are looking at the age group of 18-50, the percentage of people using WhatsApp for communication will be greater in rich section group. I will take 70% usage rate among rich folks and 60% among the middle section. That gives WhatsApp users among rich and middle to be .7*.2*15 =2.1 M and .6*.5*15=4.5 M respectively. Total users=6.6 M



Among the income group, I would like to classify users depending on their messaging frequency.

They could be classified as heavy, medium and light. The heavy users will be the younger age group who use WhatsApp for chatting with their friends/ batchmates and various class/interest groups. The medium users of WhatsApp would be the working population in the age group of 25-35 (say) who would be busy in their work and have less time to devote to informal chats. Light users would

Guesstimate 03

form an age group of 35+ who spend less time on app and their major messaging happens via family groups and close friends. Does this assumption sound reasonable?

Interviewer: Sure, we can proceed. How would you estimate the number of messages sent by these users?

Candidate: For heavy users , who would be primarily the younger group, I would estimate the number of hours spent on smartphones to be 14 and assuming 50 messages sent per hour on average, that would be 14*50=700 messages per heavy user a day, I would take medium and light users to send .7*700 =490 , (say 500 for calculation) and 200 messages respectively per day. For the user split I would assume a 40,40,20 percentage split across heavy , medium and light users for the 6.6 M WhatsApp users. This would give us the number of messages sent per day to be:
.4*6.6*700 + 0.4*6.6*500 +0.2*6.6*200= 3432 M messages.

Interviewer: This looks good. We can close it here.

Comment: We could alternatively calculate population distribution of the respective age groups(18-24, 25-35,35-50) in a high, medium and low frequency messaging basis. Every age group would have a different percentage split across three modes of frequency usage. The number of messages sent across the 3 age groups and 3 modes of frequency would also be different. We would end up with 9 unique entries for an age group- mode combination. (e.g. 18-24 High). Multiplying no of users and messages sent daily for each such 9 combination and adding it up would give us the total number of WhatsApp messages sent every day in Kolkata.

Some more guesstimates

Estimate the bandwidth (internet) required at Kolkata Airport.

The bandwidth required can be estimated as:
Number of passengers on 1 day at airport * Max usage per customer per second

- Number of runways at the airport = 1
- Total time = 24 hours
- Maintenance time = 4 hours
- Time to take-off per flight = 5 minutes

Number of flights in one day
= (20*60)/5 = 240 flights

Flights can be segmented as domestic and international. Let us take 30% international and 70% domestic flights.

Number of seats in international flight
= 9 columns * 30 rows = 180 seats
Number of seats in domestic flight
= 6 columns * 20 seats = 120 seats

Occupancy for each flight will be decided by the time of the day. Flights can be segmented based on high, medium and low traffic time. International and domestic flights will be different for the 3 time slots.

[Use it to distribute the number of international and domestic flights in high, medium and low traffic times but was told to consider a uniform distribution.]

For domestic, consider 90% occupancy in high, 70% in medium and 50% in low traffic time. For international, take 80% in high, 60% in medium and 40% in low traffic time

Number of people visiting the airport in 1 day = (240 * 0.3 * 180 *0.6) + (240 * 0.7 * 120 * 0.7)
= 7776 + 14112 = 21888 (approx. 22000)

Amount of bandwidth required differs for high, medium and low usage customers. College students (video call, streaming), office workers/middle age group (WhatsApp calls, office work), senior people (internet messaging).

- Video call takes 500MB for 5min
- Audio call takes 100MB for 5min (assumption)
- Internet messaging takes 500KB for 1min (assumption)

The highest usage will be for video call, so bandwidth required = number of people * maximum bandwidth = 22000 * 100MB per min = 22000 * 100MB/60 sec ~ 36666MB per sec

Calculate the number of tickets booked in Kolkata from BookMyShow

First discuss the approach and then go on doing calculations and arrive at the final answer.

Number of malls in Kolkata = Area of Kolkata (200)/Area served by a mall (25)
Total number of seats available in Kolkata = No. of malls x No. of screens (4) x No. of seats in a screen (200)

Calculating % of seats booked by BookMyShow using internet penetration rate in Kolkata (60% internet penetration) x (50% booked on BMS)

Calculating average occupancy rate based on the day of the week (70%)
Total bookings in a day = No. of seats x occupancy rate

Some more guesstimates

Estimate the number of parking spaces that are required at the Bangalore airport

Identify the different types of vehicles that can come at the airport like airport authority vehicles, government authority vehicles, Uber/Ola cabs, normal cabs, personal vehicles, luggage transport vehicles.

Given by interviewer: Ola/Uber cabs

Approach: Estimate the throughput of the cabs from Bangalore airport at the busiest hour and based on average waiting time for each cab, calculate the number of cabs that will be parked in that hour. Either looking at departure or arrival numbers would work since Bangalore airport is quite far from the city, any cab visiting the airport will leave the airport with a ride only.

- Consider the busiest hour and checked the number of people that would come at that hour.
- Check the percentage of people requiring cabs. Assume cab sharing and private cab model and estimate average number of passengers per cab. Calculate number of cabs that will be coming to/leaving the airport in that hour.
- So number of parking spaces required at any given time for cabs = Number of cabs going out in any time period (hour for the case) * (Cab TAT/time period)

Estimate the water consumption in an apartment building

Water is used for these primary functions – cooking, bathing, cleaning, drinking.

Estimate the daily water requirement for cooking, bathing and drinking for a child and a grown up, and the water requirement for cleaning a 1500 sqft of space which can be assumed to be the average size of a flat.

Next assume a medium sized apartment complex with 50 flats with different types of families – 4 and 8 people respectively. Next calculate the total consumption by multiplying individual usage by total number of residents.

Finally add some overhead for common building consumption.

How many photos are uploaded on facebook on a monthly basis?

Clarify the user scale and segment them based on frequency of uploads and the percentage of photos among uploads.
Assume seasonality and clarify on every step whether the approach makes sense or not.
Interviewer can ask to calculate the exact number and compare it with the number he has by the end, so make sure to have basic numbers crunched for top down approach.

Go-to-Market Cases



GTM Case I

You are PM at the Myntra building for India. You're tasked to come up with a Go to Market strategy for a home-cooked meal delivery application that Myntra has come up with.

Candidate: Thank you for the context. To start, could you clarify if the goal is to launch this home-cooked meal delivery application nationwide in India?

Interviewer: Yes, your task is to devise a strategy for a nationwide launch.

Candidate: Great. I'll begin by analyzing the current landscape for home-cooked meal delivery services in India. Currently, there's a growing trend toward online food delivery platforms, including cooked meals. We have established players like Swiggy and Zomato, which offer a variety of restaurant food. However, there's a noticeable gap in the market for homemade, healthy, and customizable meals delivered to consumers' doorsteps. This presents an opportunity for Myntra to leverage its brand and platform.

Interviewer: How does Myntra's brand fit into this market, and what unique value can we offer?

Candidate: Myntra's brand is synonymous with fashion and lifestyle, and we have a large and loyal customer base. Leveraging our brand recognition and customer trust, we can position this service as a fashion-forward, health-conscious meal delivery platform. The key differentiator will be our focus on homemade meals prepared by local home chefs.

We can emphasize the authenticity, quality, and health benefits of home-cooked food. Additionally, our platform can offer customization options, allowing users to tailor their meals to their dietary preferences and requirements.

Interviewer: That sounds promising. How would you propose launching this service?

Candidate: I'd suggest dividing the Go to Market strategy into three phases: Pre-launch, Launch, and Post-launch.

1. **Pre-launch:** We should begin by conducting a soft launch in a few major cities to test the market's response and gather user feedback. This will help us fine-tune the platform and build initial awareness. We can also start partnering with local home chefs in these cities.
2. **Launch:** For the nationwide launch, we should organize a virtual launch event. Given Myntra's fashion expertise, we can host a fashion-meets-food event, collaborating with renowned designers and home chefs. This will create buzz and generate media coverage. We should also launch a marketing campaign highlighting the benefits of homemade meals, healthiness, and customization.
3. **Post-launch**: After the launch, we should focus on user engagement and retention. Implementing a robust loyalty program and referral system can incentivize users to keep ordering. Additionally, leveraging Myntra's existing customer base, we can cross-promote the meal delivery service within the fashion app.

Interviewer: What distribution channels do you suggest for this service?

GTM Case I

Candidate: I propose launching this service as a standalone application initially, dedicated solely to home-cooked meal delivery. We can also integrate it within the Myntra fashion app as a separate section, targeting existing Myntra customers who may be interested in the service. This dual-channel approach allows us to tap into both existing Myntra users and new customers.

Interviewer: Lastly, how would you address user retention and satisfaction?

Candidate: User retention in the food delivery industry is heavily dependent on the quality of service and user experience. We should closely monitor user feedback and ratings, ensuring that meals consistently meet expectations. Implementing a review and rating system for home chefs will help maintain quality.
Additionally, we should offer a loyalty program where users can earn rewards for repeated orders. Regular engagement through personalized recommendations and promotions tailored to individual preferences can also enhance retention.

Interviewer: Thank you for your comprehensive strategy. Could you please summarize the key points?

Candidate: Certainly. The strategy for Myntra's home-cooked meal delivery application focuses on leveraging our brand recognition, emphasizing healthiness and customization, and partnering with local home chefs. It involves a phased approach with a soft launch, a fashionable nationwide launch event, and post-launch efforts to enhance user retention through quality assurance, loyalty programs, and personalized engagement. This strategy aims to position Myntra as a unique player in the Indian meal delivery market, capitalizing on our fashion-forward brand and existing customer base

GTM Case 2

A tech startup is launching a new Virtual Reality (VR) fitness app that allows users to experience immersive workouts at home. Develop a Go-to-Market strategy for this app.

Candidate: Thank you for the context. Just to clarify the goal is to launch a VR fitness app that allows users to experience workouts at home, and can I assume the geography to be pan India?

Interviewer: Yes, your task is to devise a nationwide launch in India.

Candidate: Got it. Can you please provide some differentiating factors or unique features of the VR fitness app that differentiate us from the competitors?

Interviewer: The app boasts many immersive workouts, from virtual environments to personalized training programs. It also integrates with various VR headsets for a more engaging experience.

Candidate: Okay, and do we know how the market is performing, and whether it is growing?

Interviewer: In India, the fitness market is experiencing an increasing demand in India with a CAGR of 14.3%, India's VR market is expected to reach $5.3 billion by 2027, with affordable VR headsets like JioGlass gaining traction.

Candidate: Understood. Do we have any information about the competitors? A few of them that I can remember of are Gymbal which offers live interactive workouts using mobile cameras and wearables, Flexnest which combines smart connected equipment with immersive content for home workouts and some emerging startups like BeyondFit and VRFit. We must differentiate ourselves from them by providing personalized content based on their lifestyle.

Interviewer: You can go ahead with that.

Candidate: Okay, then. So, first I would like to look at the product and its target audience, point of differentiation. Then, accordingly tailor the GTM strategy.

Interviewer: What do you have in mind for the product?

Candidate: An immersive and tailored app for catering to the demand of the Indian audience should keep the following in mind, in India, there is a low penetration of VR headsets, and it is a data usage-sensitive market. We must invest highly in content creators to develop niche content around fitness.

Target Audience:

- Fitness enthusiasts aged 18-35 in urban and semi-urban areas.
- Data-conscious and value-seeking consumers who are open to new technologies.
- Subgroups within the target audience based on fitness goals, preferred workout styles, and language.

Unique selling features:

- A tailored app that provides customized fitness routines for customers based on their lifestyle.
- Available in various languages catering to

GTM Case 2

- different cultures.
- Offers personalized training, VR/AR experiences, and a vibrant community.

Does that sound fair?

Interviewer: That sounds promising. So, how would you devise a strategy to enter the market?

Candidate: Here is the strategy:

1. Pre-launch:
   - Generate buzz through social media contests, influencer partnerships, and collaborations with local fitness brands and VR startups.
   - Create hype with teaser videos showcasing immersive workouts and local cultural integration.
   - Build an email list for early access and exclusive offers.
2. Launch:
   - Partner with affordable VR headset brands like JioGlass for bundled offers or free trials.
   - Secure media coverage in fitness and tech publications, targeting relevant Indian outlets.
   - Launch on major app stores with regional language support and localized visuals.
   - Offer a freemium model with limited features and paid subscriptions for premium content and personalized plans.
3. Post-launch:
   - Leverage user data to personalize recommendations and content.
   - Foster community engagement through challenges, leaderboards, and group workouts.
   - Run targeted ads on social media and mobile platforms based on user personas.
   - Host live events and workshops with Indian fitness celebrities and VR/AR experts.
   - Continuously update content with new workouts, VR environments, and features.

Distribution Channels: For distribution, I propose leveraging both online and offline channels. We can launch the app on popular app stores for easy accessibility. Additionally, partnerships with VR headset manufacturers can ensure pre-installation or exclusive promotions.

Pricing: To encourage adoption, I recommend a freemium model. Users can access basic workouts for free, with an option to unlock premium content, personalized training plans, and advanced features through a subscription-based model. This ensures accessibility while generating revenue from dedicated users.

Metrics for success:

- App downloads, active users, and engagement rate.
- Conversion rate from free to paid subscriptions.
- User feedback and reviews.
- Brand awareness and social media mentions.
- Growth in community participation and local user base.

Interviewer: That is a comprehensive strategy. So, what do you think could be challenges that we could face while tapping into the Indian market?

Candidate: Sure, here are the few challenges

we can face. As VR penetration in India is not so high, we must educate the market about immersive fitness and VR/AR technology. We have to optimize data usage concerns, building trust and awareness in a competitive market would also be a problem. We would have to ensure affordability and accessibility for diverse income levels and need to constantly adapt to changing scenarios like contents and regional variations and languages.

Interviewer: Okay, thank you for the comprehensive strategy.

Comment: As you see, this GTM has been discussed in much more depth than the first one. Not all factors may be discussed, and candidate must take cues from the interviewer. These must be mentioned to the interviewer before going in depth.

GTM Case 3

Netflix wants to enter the sports streaming market in India. You are appointed as the product manager to plan a strategy for market entry. What would you do? Should Netflix enter the sports market in India?

Candidate: Do I need to focus on any sport to start with?

Interviewer: You don't have any restrictions. Please state your assumptions and propose a strategy.

Candidate: Is there a customer segment or geography you have in mind?

Interviewer: As I said, you are free to propose these and state your reasons behind them.

Candidate: Thank you. Can I take a couple of minutes to gather my thoughts?

Interviewer: Sure.

Candidate: Netflix is known for three things. (i) No advertisements (ii) They like to own their content (iii) They are truly global.
Unfortunately, sports do not fit in either of these 3 criteria. Sports revenue relies heavily on advertisements and sponsors. No media company owns sports telecasts. They bid for TV/ media rights every few years. Except for a few sports like football(soccer), and Olympic sports, no sport is truly global. Every country/ region has a different sport that is popular. For example, in the USA, American Football, Baseball, and Basketball are popular. In India, Cricket is the most popular sport. Also, the rules of the sport are designed in a way that advertisements can be shown. For example, the time outs and breaks in cricket are an opportunity for the broadcaster to show advertisements. So, I will assume that Netflix will move away from its traditional business models. Is that ok?

Interviewer: That's fine.

Candidate: Let me start with competition analysis:
Competition Analysis - Hotstar is the market leader in sports OTT followed by Sony Liv. Hotstar has the rights to ISL (Indian super league football), Indian kabaddi league, and EPL (English premier league football). It had the IPL cricket rights and Formula I races. Now Jio Cinema is aggressively entering sports with winning bids for the FIFA world cup and IPL. Formula I governing body FIA has started its own streaming app.
Market Sizing - Do you want me to estimate the market size.

Interviewer: Do not worry about the market size. Please assume the market is attractive. Go ahead and focus on the strategy part.

Candidate: Thank you. Let me continue with the strategy. I will propose a target sport and pricing strategy.
Target Sport - The obvious thing in India would be to target cricket (IPL or world cup) broadcasting rights.2023 ICC world cup is over. So, I propose that next year's IPL 2024 is the tournament Netflix must target. IPL 2024 rights are also already given. But for the sake of this case, I will assume Netflix can bid for it.
Pricing - I propose not to increase the subscription cost. The strategy is to onboard

new users and get them hooked to Netflix with the wide range of other content Netflix has. Also increasing the pricing will not go well with the existing customers.

Candidate: I would now move to the business case and profitability. How much does an OTT player pay BCCI for IPL rights?

Interviewer: Please assume about INR 5000 Crore for 5 seasons.

Candidate: How much does an OTT platform make in revenues from an advertisement? Do you want me to estimate or propose a pricing strategy for advertisements?

Interviewer: You can assume revenue of INR 1200 Crore per season for advertisements.

Candidate: Just with the numbers above, the cost for 5 years is INR 5000 Crore. There could be additional costs. Inviting experts (ex-cricketers/ commentators) to analyze the inning break or pre and post-match shows. Promotion costs on various platforms- online (YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, etc.) and offline (newspapers, TV ads) that IPL will be telecast on Netflix. Can I assume INR 100 Crore per season?

Interviewer: Sure

Candidate: Total Costs now for 5 seasons are INR 5500 Crore (5000 Cr+500Cr). The revenue for 5 seasons will be INR 6000 Crore from advertisements (1200 Cr x 5). Also, we could have additional revenue because of new users buying Netflix subscriptions during IPL. How many subscribers does Netflix have today in India?

Interviewer: Please assume about 6 Million

Candidate: 6 Million is 60 Lakhs. I will assume that another 40 Lakhs will subscribe to Netflix during the IPL season. To be conservative, I assume they take the mobile-only plan (INR 149 per month). I assume 5 Lakh people will continue using Netflix because of the other content Netflix has, and not interested in sports. Is that a fair assumption?

Interviewer: Yes. That's fine.

Candidate: Total revenue per year from new subscribers during the IPL season only= 35 Lakhs X INR 149 X 2 months. For ease of calculation, I will assume 150 INR as the monthly subscription fee. Total revenue per year from new subscribers during the IPL season only = INR 105 Crore
Total revenue per year from new subscribers who will continue for the rest of the year= 5 Lakhs X 150 INR X 12= INR 90 Crore
Total revenue because of new subscribers for 5 years= INR 195 Crore X 5= INR 975 Crore

Total Revenue= INR 6000 Crore (Advertisements)+ INR 975 Crore= **INR 6975 Crore**
Total Costs= **INR 5500 Crore**
The gap between revenue and costs is high, so it will be a great move for Netflix to explore the sports streaming market in India. They can generate more revenue and add more users to their ecosystem. They should definitely consider entering the sports streaming market in India.

GTM Case 4

Let us pretend you are a brand-new Product Manager at Amazon. Tell me how you would determine the next big thing for us and then walk me through your idea for it.

Candidate: I would start from Amazon's core competencies. Ideas that start with a company's strengths are more sustainable in the long-term. Here is a list of the Amazon products I can think of - Amazon.com, Amazon Fresh, Amazon Digital Services, Amazon Prime Video, Amazon Fire TV, Amazon Web Services, Amazon Advertising, Twitch, Kindle, and Alexa. Let me know if I missed any major products.

Interviewer: That looks like pretty comprehensive.

Candidate: I am going to first think about Amazon's strengths. Building something new is easier when we're building on top of strength. Then we'll think about opportunities, especially if there are marketplace gaps not well served by our competitors or us. Lastly, I'll outline some potential threats and highlight past mistakes that should be avoided. Can I have some time to brainstorm?

Interviewer: Sure

Candidate: Okay, let's first go over Amazon's strengths as a company:

- Vast Resources and Scale.
- Risk-Embracing Culture. For example, the Kindle was a success while the Amazon Phone wasn't. The opposite could have turned out to be true, but the only way to know was to launch these products.
- Competitive, Business-Savvy DNA.
- Focus on the Customer. Does this sound right for you?

Interviewer: Yes, it does, please go on.

Candidate: Great. Now, here are some markets where Amazon is already successful in:

- Ecommerce.
- Cloud Infrastructure.
- E-books. E-books are interesting, but the potential is smaller than e-commerce's.

Interviewer: What e-commerce opportunities would you consider?

Candidate: I can think of a few ideas:

- Amazon Games. We need something to attract developers to develop games for the Amazon platform, including Amazon Fire TV. Phones didn't succeed because not enough developers adopted it, meaning not enough content. Fire TV is doing okay; developing games for it would help. With so many games 250 sold on Amazon.com already, this would be a great natural fit. Twitch would also contribute by streaming games and hosting tournaments. This might seem trivial today, but video games keep increasing in popularity. With ever-more immersive VR experiences, combined with Twitch's distribution platform, 10 years from now, professional gamers might be considered in the same breath as professional athletes.
- Amazon Browser. Google is a major threat to Amazon. Its search engine and browser dominance means that Google can subvert a user's journey toward Amazon. Just imagine, Google can distract Amazon customers with product offers and competitive alternatives.

GTM Case 4

- Amazon is doing a good job building customer awareness that commercial searches should start with Amazon; a recent study showed that over 50% of purchase-related searches start on Amazon, not Google. By having our own browser, we further protect ourselves. A browser improves our understanding of user intent and Internet usage behavior, which can improve analytics and ad targeting. And any information we collect is less information that Google collects. We can start by making our Amazon browser the default on Kindles.
- Amazon Capital. We mentioned before that Amazon is a company with deep business roots. Given the number of merchants that sell on Amazon.com and startups that host their products on AWS, these customers may be tomorrow's leading businesses. Amazon could use their performance data, on either Amazon.com or AWS, to signal which companies have the best prospects. From there, Amazon can provide equity or debt financing. Is there a specific opportunity you want me to expand on?

Interviewer: Why don't you walk me through Amazon Capital in more detail?

Candidate: Of course. There are two main ways Amazon could invest in companies:

- Loan money for expansion
- Invest in exchange for equity

It's hard to predict which one would work best, so I'd experiment with both to start. Over time we'll see which one has the bigger payoff. Although the concept is new to Amazon, it's not totally unproven. Google has an investing arm called CapitalG; some of their most successful investments include Uber, Lyft, Airbnb, and SurveyMonkey. Amazon's culture is even more business-oriented than Google's. I don't see why we wouldn't have a shot at this market. Also, Amazon as a company has been successful in managing multiple distinct businesses, such as Amazon.com, AWS, and Zappos. In other words, history has shown that Amazon isn't easily distracted with seemingly dissimilar businesses.

Interviewer: Interesting. But aren't there huge risks associated with startup investing?

Candidate: Yes. The biggest risk is that a startup fails, and you lose your entire investment in that company. But here's the interesting thing: since Amazon's portfolio companies are likely to be Amazon customers. So 251 whatever revenue Amazon generates from AWS or third-party merchant fees offsets any potential investment loss. Another risk is adverse selection. Most investors do not have a clear and accurate picture on how startups are performing. This leads good money to chase after bad companies. Amazon can audit a startup's Amazon services (e.g. AWS) data to verify whether a startup is performing as advertised. We can never completely remove all the risk associated with an idea, but it does seem that Amazon's unfair "data" advantage can help us become a successful investor.

Interviewer: Thank you.

Pricing Cases



Pricing Case I

How would you price the Kindle Fire HD?

Candidate: My understanding is that Kindle Fire HD is a 7-inch tablet with an HD display. I'm not familiar with the tablet market. Do I mind if ask you a few questions?

Interviewer: Sure, go ahead.

Candidate: Who are its main competitors?

Interviewer: The main competitors are the iPad Mini, Samsung Galaxy Tab, and Google's Nexus 7.

Candidate: How much do those retail for?

Interviewer: The iPad Mini retails for $329 while the Galaxy Tab and Nexus 7 sell for $199.

Candidate: What makes Kindle Fire HD standout from its competition?

Interviewer: Kindle Fire HD has a higher resolution than the Galaxy Tab and iPad Mini.

Candidate: My last question: How much does it cost to make a Kindle Fire HD

Interviewer: a market research firm, iSuppli, disassembled a Kindle Fire HD and publicly estimated that each Kindle Fire HD costs $174 to make.

Candidate: Thanks for the background information. There are three different ways we can look at pricing:

- Customer's willingness to pay
- Competitive pricing
- Cost-based pricing

I'll go through each one by one now.

- First, I'd think about the customer. If they didn't have the product, what would they do instead? How much they would pay for an alternative or substitute product? Negotiators call this the BATNA or the best alternative to a negotiated agreement. Here, I'll call it the customer's willingness to pay for the product. It represents the maximum a customer would pay for the product.

- In this case, if a customer couldn't buy a Kindle Fire HD, the best alternative device (the competition) is the Nexus 7. It has specifications, especially screen resolution, that's most similar to the Fire HD. The Nexus 7 costs $199, so that likely is the most we could charge for the Kindle Fire HD.

- Next, using the cost-based pricing method, we look at Kindle Fire HD's unit cost of $174. We can add an absolute or relative markup to the unit's final price. Knowing how strategic the Fire HD is to selling additional digital content, it's possible that Amazon could pursue the "razor and razor blade" strategy. That is, sell the Kindle Fire HD at, or below, cost, and make its profits on future digital content sales. Given this, let's say the pricing lower bound could be $174.

After this, I'd like to do some basic checks for the pricing at hand.
One, we compare prices with what's already on the market. The Nexus 7 and the Galaxy Tab are selling for $199.

Two, we should evaluate supply and demand. Limited supply and high demand might merit a higher price point while the inverse might merit the reverse. To build a demand curve,

we can test different price points. From that data, we can extrapolate the right price to maximize overall product profits.

Interviewer: So what's your recommendation?

Candidate: Given the urgency, there's no time to experiment and derive a supply and demand curve. Based on the discussion, we've got a tight pricing bound from $174 to $199. I would recommend the low end of the pricing spectrum, $174. Amazon needs to protect its core business of selling books, music, and movies. In the digital world, iTunes and Google Play can sell books. By ceding control of the platform, the tablet, Amazon will find it hard to compete. It's more important that Amazon wins market share now and create a strong distribution footprint of tablets. Using the Kindle Fire HD as a loss leader, strong distribution footprint of tablets. Using the Kindle Fire HD as a loss leader, Amazon can generate profits on future sales of digital content.

Pricing Case 2

How would you go about pricing UberXL?

Candidate: So, first I would like to clarify that UberX refers to the Uber service of travelling in comparatively more premium cars, compared to Uber Go and other services, usually a 6-seater.

Interview: Yes, that's the one.

Candidate: Understood. In real life, I would run a pricing survey with prospects. However, I imagine you want a back-of-the-envelope pricing calculation, correct?

Interviewer: That's correct. Nevertheless, your pricing survey suggestion is noted.

Candidate: Okay. So, there are multiple variables we need to think about to price UberX. My top 4 include:

- Supplier Costs: The main supplier is the Uber driver. We need to consider the driver's opportunity cost. The driver's opportunity cost includes both compensation from alternative work options and car maintenance costs such as gas and repairs.
- Customer's Willingness to Pay: Customers have different transportation choices including walking or driving their own cars. They can also take cabs or public transit.
- Uber's Commission: Uber provides value by matching drivers with customers. Just imagine how hard it would be to complete a transaction if it weren't for Uber. I am thinking a 30% commission to start.
- Bonus Rates: There may not be enough cars, so Uber may need to increase fees to attract more drivers. This could double or even triple during holidays.

I am going to make some assumptions. Fuel is around INR 100/litre. A fuel-efficient car has about 20 kmpl. So fuel costs for each km is INR 5. But fuel prices can go up, there's car maintenance costs, and most importantly, there's the driver's time. So let's factor that in. I would say we should increase the price to INR 7.5 to 10 per km as a lower bound.

Most trips probably take about 15 km. If you combine that with the car coming in and the time it takes to communicate, it should be around 30 minutes per trip. Therefore, we are talking 7 to 8 km and 2 trips per hour. Also, a driver may not get a passenger every time you are done, so to be safe it should be about 1.5 trips per hour.
So assuming if we did $1.50 per mile and there are 1.5 trips per hour.

Doing the math brings us to $45. If Uber take a 30% cut, that's $31.50 for the driver and $13.50 for Uber. This is the bare minimum, which is more expensive than the Caltrain.
If it's rush hour or holidays, it could go up to $40 per trip or even $60. This number seems good.

Finally, we need to add in a price for starting an Uber ride; otherwise people will try to do really short trips, which is bad for profit. On the other hand, that seems unfair to users who take long trips. A compromise would be to have a minimum ride cost, of say $5. This way, a driver in a more urban setting who ends up doing many short rides will maximize their earnings, but we can still offer great value to our passengers on long rides.
To conclude, I would price it as $1.50 per mile with $5 as a minimum charge for every ride.

Interviewer: That sounds fine.

Unconventional Cases



Unconventional Case I

Increase MS Paint users by 6 times in 6 months

I. Comprehend the Situation (C):
MS Paint is right now seen as a classic drawing application for children with very basic features. Though there is an advance version of MS paint i.e. Paint 3D, but it does not have the popularity that MS Paint enjoys.
As we want to significantly increase user base (6x) within a short timeframe (6 months) we should focus on doing rapid user acquisitions.

2. Identify the Customer (I):
Stakeholders: Casual Users, Corporate employees, Digital Artists, College/School students, Art coaching centers.

User Personals:
1. The Creative Pro
2. The Casual Creator
3. The Nostalgic Reviver
4. The Tech-Savvy Explorer
5. The Art-School teacher
6. The School/College Student

(The personas are identified keeping the different needs and behaviours in mind and should be as MECE as possible)

Target audience:
As MS Paint is famous for casual usage by children in school, exploring the photo editing market would be most beneficial to get the 6x traction.
So targeting the creative pros and casual creator user segment and repositioning the app as an editing solution.

3. Report the Customer's Needs (R):
Pro Users:
- As a pro, I need high-level editing features

Processing precision and time should be able to handle large images
- Having advanced and customizable editing options
- Workspaces, keyboard shortcuts, and macro creation for personalised workflows

Casual Users
- Preset filters and AI-powered editing
- Effortless professional look
- Funny features and filters
- Easy sharing options

Shared Needs:
- Offer a freemium model with essential features for casual users and a premium version with advanced tools for professionals at a competitive price point

4. Cut through Prioritization (C):
As we have already prioritised the target segments let's perform MASCOW to identify feature to build solutions:

Must-haves:
- Precise selection and masking tools
- Advanced non-destructive adjustments
- Efficient batch processing and automation
- Raw image support and noise reduction
- One-click filters and presets with diverse styles and effects
- Playful stickers, overlays, and text tools
- Mobile-optimised interface with touch-screen and stylus support

Should-haves:
- Customizable workspaces and keyboard shortcuts
- Direct social sharing integration
- Hardware integration with styluses and other input methods
- Regular updates with new features and bug fixes

Unconventional Case I

Could-haves:

- Advanced HDR editing tools
- Macro creation
- Integration with augmented reality or virtual reality experiences
- Active community engagement and feedback

Won't-haves:

- Complicated 3D rendering or animation features
- Comprehensive tutorial library and community forum

5. List Solutions (L):

- Storyteller and Animator

It will be an in-built feature with a lot of drag and drop options which will help professionals and budding artists to ace their projects with the help of MS Paint.

- AI Image creator

This feature will convert texts to images using the in-built LLM models and help creators to push their boundaries while creating content.

- Collaborative editor with Live Editing

This feature is for a team of professionals who want to work together on creative work and creating original content with live editing features.

6. Evaluate Tradeoffs (E):

Selecting The Storyteller and Animator Feature as the best solution as

It will have easy-to-use animation tools, engaging storytelling potential, suitable for all ages and skill levels. The target audience would be pro users, casual users, creative individuals, educators, kids, thus having a large pool of new users.

7. Summarise Recommendation (S):

The goal is to boost MS Paint users sixfold in six months by repositioning it as a versatile editing tool. Identified target audiences include creative pros and casual creators seeking advanced editing and effortless, fun features. Prioritised features encompass precise tools, batch processing, and a freemium model. Proposed solutions include an intuitive Storyteller and Animator tool, an AI Image Creator, and a Collaborative Editor with Live Editing. The selected Storyteller and Animator solution offers engaging, user-friendly animation tools, appealing to a broad audience from professionals to kids, making it the optimal choice for rapid user acquisition.

Key metrics to track:

- Usage Rate: Measure how frequently users engage with the Storyteller and Animator feature.
- Adoption Percentage: Track the proportion of MS Paint users actively using this new tool.
- Conversion Metrics: Monitor the rate of users trying and continuing to use the Storyteller and Animator.
- Feedback and Reviews: Analyse user sentiments and reviews specific to this feature.
- Sharing Frequency: Measure how often creations from the Storyteller and Animator are shared on social platforms, indicating its appeal and potential reach.

Unconventional Case 2

Design a smart table for a restaurant.

I. Comprehend the Situation (C):

Assuming we are a manufacturing company who wants to create smart IoT products that can be used in a restaurant in place of their traditional tables. Right now the restaurant industry majorly has traditional sitting arrangements focusing mostly on luxury and comfort rather than technical advancements. So, our product will give a new flavour by increasing the user engagement and also it will be a premium service that can attract new users.

2. Identify the Customer (I):

Stakeholders: our major stakeholders would be the restaurant, customers, hotels and hotel chains, where customers are our primary stakeholder.

User Personals:

I. Family with kids

2. Budget-conscious friends group

3. Tech-savvy foodies

(The personas are identified keeping the different needs and behaviours in mind and should be as MESE as possible)

Target audience:

As most of the restaurants are family restaurants, focusing on the family with kids user persona will generate the most reach.

3. Report the Customer's Needs (R):

To understand the customer pain points and needs we can explode the user journey while visiting a restaurant.

· As a family with kids, when I visit a restaurant, usually we book a table, then everybody gets seated and waits for the menu to arrive.

· Based on the number of menus that we got we try sharing the menu within ourselves and order our individual or group orders.

· After we have selected what to order we have to call the waiter and wait for the waiter to receive the order.

· While waiting for the orders, we also had to keep the kids engaged.

· Once we finish our meal or even in between meals when we want to reorder something, we need to wait for the waiter. And when at the end the waiter arrives, We ask for the bill and the preferred payment method and pay accordingly.

· Sometimes, we also have to wait for the QR scanner or card swipe machine to come.

So the major needs identified through the user journey are:

I. As a family with kids, all of the members want easy and hassle-free access to the menu.

2. As a family with kids, we need something to keep the kids engaged.

3. As a family with kids, we need easy communication, ordering and payment options.

4. As a family with kids, our elders should have easy accessibility and readability of all the services.

5. As a family with kids, we need some entertainment options while waiting for the food.

4. Cut through Prioritization (C):

Out of all the needs the most effective would be to have easy communication, ordering and payment option, as it will benefit not only the customers but also the restaurants to improve service quality

5. List Solutions (L):

To solve the particular pain point the dining table can be equipped with some basic features of IoT devices, so our proposed solutions are:

Unconventional Case 2

- **A table with modular drawers having interactive touch screen:**

This feature will have individual drawers for every seat, and the drawers will have a touch screen for seeing the menu, ordering food, playing video games, watching movies and also paying the bills.

- **A table with a private network facilitating all the services through a smartphone:**

Every table will be equipped with a microchip which can be connected with the customer smartphone using their Wi-Fi, and it will take them to a private network where they can see the menu, order their food, check out the restaurant amenities, check information about our food and beverage services, watch movies which are pre downloaded into the private network and pay the bill at the end using their smartphones.

- **A table with a Voice Assistant:**

This feature will be very similar to an Amazon Alexa, which will have a conversation with the customer, understand their food preferences, will explain the food options, and we will try to find an order for the preferred food for the customer by itself.

6. Evaluate Trade-offs (E):

Here we will use the RICE framework to understand which of these 3 solutions will be the best.

Initial assumptions for the RICE framework:

1. For Reach taking the total percentage of existing users using the feature Which is scaled down to 1-5.
2. For Impact, 3 = massive impact, 2 = high impact, 1 = medium impact, 0.5 = low impact, 0.25 = minimal impact
3. Confidence is the level of surety on the reach and impact values which is scaled down to 1-5.
4. Effort is the number of person-months needed to implement this feature which is scaled down to 1-5.

Improvement/Feature	Reach	Impact	Confidence	Effort	Score(R*I*C/E)
Interactive Touchscreen	3	4	3	4	9
Private Network	4	3	4	3	16
Voice Assistant	3	3	3	3	9

Private Network with Smartphone Integration emerges as the potential frontrunner with a high overall score of 16.0. Its broad reach (4) and moderate impact (3) are balanced by high confidence (4) and relatively lower effort (3) in implementation.

Modular Drawers with Interactive Touchscreens follow closely with a score of 9.0, boasting a high impact (4) and potential for a unique experience but requiring more effort (4) and facing limitations in reach (3) due to its dependence on specific user demographics.

·Voice Assistant also scores a 9.0, offering a balance between the three factors but its success could be highly dependent on the chosen technology and implementation quality.

7. Summarise Recommendation (S):

To summarise the case we wanted to create a smart table for restaurants, as our major stakeholders are the customers and most of the restaurants being family restaurants we prioritised the family with kids user persona

to be our primary target. Then we tried understanding some potential solutions that will help us to increase user engagement. Out of the 3 solutions we tried finding the best one using the RICE framework. Through rice the second solution of having a private network made most sense, as most of the customers will have access to a smartphone and creating a website is a very low intensive job and the IoT devices that will be connected to the table will be also very cheap in this regard where we are just providing a private network.

The key metrics to track this particular feature/product:

I. **Network usage rate:** Identify how many customers out of the total are actually connecting to the private network, higher percentage will show more engagement with the product.

2. **Wait time:** if the average weight time is reducing that will indicate that the feature is working pretty well.

3. **Customer satisfaction:** if the average rating of the restaurant goes up after this particular product is introduced it will indicate more customer satisfaction through the product.

4. **Average order value:** if there is a visible increase in the average order value that will give estimation of more customer engagement.

List of Practice Cases



Cases You Can Practise

Product Design

- **Product Design (Software)**
  - Design a Bicycle rental app for IIM Calcutta
  - Design an app for carpooling in the city of Kolkata
  - Design Uber for Kids
  - Design a walking app for the visually impaired
  - Design an app for the Institute library
  - Design an app for events/ concerts/ amusement parks
  - Design an app for cultural activities around people during a pandemic
  - Design a common notes taking app for students of a class
  - Design an alarm app
  - Design an ERP for IIM Calcutta
  - Design a digital solution to prevent cyber-crime & cyber bullying
  - Design a product in matrimony space that is geared towards small & medium businesses. It should be a vertical search engine where users will be able to search for any wedding requirement. The available content has to be indexed by you
  - Design a Software product to reduce costs for airlines
  - Design a security solution for a museum
  - Design a feature to increase customer acquisition of Swiggy
  - Design a product to improve conversational English for 18–25 year-old people
  - Design a music app for the visually impaired
  - Design a babysitter app (startup)
  - Integrate healthcare services in WhatsApp

App Improvement

- How would you design a deferred order feature on Zomato (ie. pre-ordering so the food arrives at a specific time)
- How would you improve LinkedIn's network feature to improve user engagement
- How would you go about adding a "Recommendations from your friends" feature on Netflix
- Design a feature for bargaining on Amazon E-commerce app
- Suggest something to improve the traffic on Inshorts/Finshot
- Improve Amazon Echo for senior citizens
- Expand Blinkit into Bangladesh
- Improve Tinder for the LGBTQ+ community
- How would go about giving suggestions to NPCI for UPI
- How would you improve the calculator app on your phone
- How would you build an integrated e-commerce platform on browser from scratch which will increase browser's market share
- How would you use the information on a person (say person X knows a lot about cloud,works on automation) from intelligence in outlook to improve existing microsoft apps
- You are PM of spotify wrapped feature, improve the feature
- Design an user engagement solution for a food delivery app
- Improve Whatsapp's user experience
- if you were the owner for splitiwse & looking to implement the functionality of splitwise as part of the other apps - How would you do it
- Improve the user engagement of PayTM

Cases You Can Practise

- **Physical Product Design**
  - Design an inflight entertainment system
  - Design a smart traffic light
  - Design an alarm clock/ computer-compatible keyboard for the blind
  - Design a smart fridge
- **Unconventional/Moonshot**
  - MYGA - Make Yahoo Great Again: How can we make Yahoo the default email/office service provider
  - Design a Time Machine
  - Design an app that takes the place of Product Managers
  - Strategize to double the DAU of Zerodha
- **Metrics/Algorithm**
  - You're the product lead of a drone manufacturing startup. Propose some success metrics to the govt of India to get your license approved
  - Metrics for recommendation algorithm for a music platform
  - Metrics for a dating app
  - Propose Metrics for a stock trading app
  - Metrics for increased range of service in a food delivery app

RCA

- **Hints Given**
  - TATA IMG has seen increased customer support tickets about order placement for the last I week.
  - Integrated with a BNPL provider on their Payment Gateway. Due to a tech backend issue, after the payment gets completed, the app is not redirecting to the order confirmation page for this set of users who used the BNPL option for payment, leading to more customer complaints about orders.
  - Amazon merchants have complained that their long-term high selling 4star+ product sales have dropped for the past 2 weeks
    - When people search on Amazon the products are displayed correctly according to the recommendation algorithm but there is an issue in displaying the stars on the product profile so the customers skip those products & choose other products. These products are also skipped when the user puts in the filter for 4Star+ products. When the user opens the product page the stars are displayed correctly.
  - Dunzo has seen on their dashboards the average order value has suddenly shot down since the past week
    - The metrics definition has changed! Earlier the metric had the order value of both executed & cancelled orders divided by the total number of orders executed. The new metric now just uses the value of executed orders over the number of orders. (If the interviewee skips to check the validity of data & metrics used you can guide them by mentioning that there has been no change in the app but we did upgrade our data & metrics provider)
- **Some more examples**
  - You are a PM at Flipkart and have seen a 30% drop in revenue. What will you do?
  - Paytm transactions suddenly dropped by 10% from yesterday
  - Customers are not renewing their Hotstar subscription. Find the cause and give suggestions.

Cases You Can Practise

Guesstimates

- How many people use Swiggy at IIM Calcutta daily?
- How many AA batteries are used in the academic block?
- How many tea cups are used in IIM Calcutta daily?
- How many API requests are made in Google Maps per day in Kolkata?
- How many cars are there in Kolkata?
- Calculate the total addressable market for toothbrushes in India
- Hpw many drones would Amazon require for pan-India delivery system?
- Air India launches free inflight wi-fi services in domestic flights. Estimate the daily average internet consumption.
- Number of texts sent on WhatsApp daily

GTM & Pricing

- Develop a freemium model for Netflix India & how would you price it
- How would you price Zomato's daily meal service
- Provide a GTM strategy for grocery subscriptions for BigBasket
- You are handling Flight booking division of MakeMyTrip. You have received a recommendation to provide an option of free cancellation. How would you decide fee for this option?
- GTM Strategy for a new medicine for asthma patients in India
- Suppose you are the product manager or product marketing manager from MyIICircle. How will you monetize the product?
- How much should MakeMyTrip price its adspace?

All the Best!

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